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KEY PROJECTS

Semicon 2.0, new urea plants get Cabinet nod

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Spain roars past France, enters final

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DELIMITATION BILL

NDA renews push for a two-thirds majority

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INSTITUTIONALISED HIERARCHY

The crisis at the heart of global non-proliferation

The Iran crisis lays bare an enduring hypocrisy

OPINION » PAGE 7



EXPEDITED PLAN

BSF to fence Sundarbans along Bangladesh border

NEWS » PAGE 8

NEARBY



Centre approves extension of Sai Kumar's tenure

CHENNAI

The Centre has approved the State government's proposal to extend the tenure of Chief Secretary M. Sai Kumar, a 1990-batch Tamil Nadu cadre IAS officer, who is due to retire in August. » PAGE 4

Eight inmates arrested in prisoner's death

NAGERCOIL

Eight inmates of the Kanniyakumari district jail have been arrested in connection with the death of remand prisoner S. Sabari Varman on Monday. » PAGE 4

METROPLUS » 4 PAGES

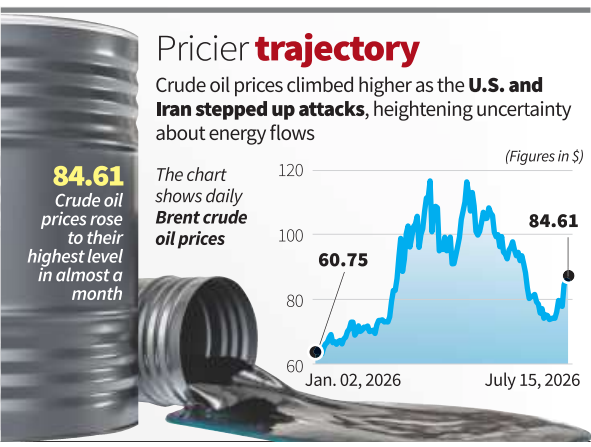
Iran threatens regional oil blockade over U.S. actions

Oil and gas 'will either be for everyone or no one', says Iran as U.S. claims 'wave of strikes'; U.S. blockade has 'dismantled' the peace MoU, says Tehran; Brent crude price nears \$85 a barrel

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN/WASHINGTON

Returning to war nearly a month after signing a memorandum of understanding towards peace in West Asia, the U.S. and Iran on Wednesday launched strikes on targets across the region.

While the U.S. Central Command said it launched "a wave of strikes... designed to further degrade military capabilities Iranian forces have used to attack commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz", Iranian state media reported explosions near the port city of Bandar Abbas, on the island of Qeshm, and on Bandar Imam Khomeini. Iranian media later said new U.S. strikes hit the southern port city of Bush-



ehr, home to the country's only civilian nuclear plant. Iran's Revolutionary Guards said they targeted the U.S. Fifth Fleet in Bahrain, where the military said it had intercepted attacks against civilian targets, while Jordan's armed forces said they had downed three missiles

from Tehran. Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said the renewed U.S. blockade on Iranian ports "has, in a way, dismantled the Islamabad memorandum", referring to the interim deal reached last month to halt hostilities and pursue peace talks.

The Guards also threatened on Wednesday to halt all energy exports from West Asia over the blockade. "The export of oil and gas from the region will be either for everyone or for no one," it said.

The Brent crude oil, the international standard, traded close to \$85 a barrel on Wednesday – more than 15% higher than the price before the war, but still below the nearly \$120 reached at the height of the conflict. Analysts with the International Monetary Fund (IMF) have warned that while a surplus of oil had kept prices low, "much of that room has now been used up".

CONTINUED ON
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TRUMP'S WARNING
» PAGE 12

HC nullifies registration of land belonging to Palani math

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court on Wednesday allowed an appeal filed by Arulmigu Dhandapani Swamigal Madam (math) in Palani, and declared as "null and void" a controversial sale deed executed in favour of certain individuals with regard to 1.35 acres of land in Palani in Dindigul district.

A Division Bench of Justices C.V. Karthikeyan and R. Sakthivel allowed the appeal against a Single Bench order that had directed the Sub-Registrar to register the sale deed if the document was otherwise in order. It said the appellant was not made a party before the Single Bench and the Sub-Registrar did not consider the objections raised before registering.

CONTINUED ON
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Kudankulam nuclear plant data leak sparks 'absolute commotion'

P. Sudhakar
TIRUNELVELI

The leak of highly sensitive files of Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant (KKNPP), reportedly accessed by a ransomware group from a contractor's server, has triggered "absolute commotion" in the plant, KKNPP sources said on Wednesday.

After commissioning two 1,000 Mwe VVER reactors, KKNPP is building four more such units with Russian collaboration.

Sources said the top brass of the upcoming nuclear park is "completely clueless" about the development that poses a security threat as it may let an adversary map the support system and identify vulnerabilities.

According to Reuters, more than 19,000 files dating between 2016 and mid-2025, and linked to KKNPP's engineering blue-



The reported data leak comes amid construction of four VVER reactors at the plant. FILE PHOTO

prints on control, cooling and ventilation systems, list of vendors and suppliers, etc. had been accessed by World Leaks.

Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited said the information claimed to be available in public domain pertains to "conventional balance of plant common service facilities" and does not relate to any nuclear safety or nuclear security-related systems.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8



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LIC/P/2026-27/10/Eng

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A CH-CH

INBRIEF



S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

SIMS performs single-incision spine surgery on octogenarian

An 84-year-old man with severe spinal compression has regained mobility after undergoing a minimally invasive endoscopic spine surgery at SIMS Hospital. The hospital said the patient had multi-level lumbar spinal stenosis and degenerative scoliosis. Instead of an open surgery with deformity correction using pedicle screws and rods, the surgical team led by G. Venkatesh Kumar and Vignesh Jayabalan, senior consultants in orthopaedics, opted for a full-endoscopic uniportal decompression through an 8-mm incision. Ravi Pachamuthu, chairman, said the hospital would continue to invest in advanced technologies.

Over 10,000 students from govt. schools across city take part in cleanliness drive

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

More than 10,000 students from government schools across the city took part in the grand finale of Swachhata Pakhwada, a cleanliness and reading campaign, organised jointly by The Hindu In School and the Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL) on Wednesday.

The event, held at the Government Girls' Higher Secondary School in Ashok Nagar, was the culmination of a fortnight-long campaign held at 50 government schools in the city. Chief Education Officer (CEO) Kabeer stressed co-curricular learning through activities such as essay



Winners of various competitions, held as part of the fortnight-long campaign, at a government school in Ashok Nagar on Wednesday.

writing and drawing competitions that encourage students to explore libraries and enhance their knowledge.

Vasuki, Principal, Government Girls' Higher Secondary School, Ashok Nagar, underscored the importance of maintaining

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

Koyambedu's Metro Rail connectivity, which was established in 2015, is set to get a massive upgrade, with stations planned for the phase II and phase III networks.

This neighbourhood boasted the earliest Chennai Metro Rail connectivity, with the launch of train services for the 45-km phase I network between

Koyambedu and Alandur in 2015.

In the 118.9-km phase II network, Koyambedu will be linked to corridor 5, which runs from Madhavaram to Sholinganallur. In the extension planned under the phase III network, Koyambedu will be linked to Pattabiram via Avadi.

According to officials of the Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL), a four-level phase II station is taking shape adjacent to the phase I station in Koyambedu. It will be opened when the stretch from Koyambedu to Chennai



Major facility: An artist's image of the phase II station being built adjacent to the phase I station in Koyambedu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Trade Centre, a part of corridor 5, is completed.

T. Archunan, director (projects), CMRL, said the

phase II station would have a street level and four upper levels. While entry/exit and parking facilities

would be provided at the street level, property development spaces have been planned at the first and second levels, which means they could be leased out for retail or commercial or co-working spaces. Ticketing facilities would come up at the third level and platforms on the fourth.

The phase I and phase II Koyambedu stations would be integrated through pedestrian connecting bridges at the ticketing level, Mr. Archunan said.

"In the phase II Koyambedu station, we have already made a provision in

the design to implement the Koyambedu-Avadi-Pattabiram corridor at the ticketing level. Like the link bridge between phase I and phase II stations, there will be a facility to connect phase II and phase III stations, too. Boarding and transiting via Koyambedu will be made seamless, and it will become a key transport interchange in the city. Residents and commuters in Koyambedu will be able to travel seamlessly to numerous locations in the phase I, phase II, and phase III networks in the future," he added.

MIOT launches emergency museum

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

MIOT International has inaugurated a public Emergency Museum – MIOT's World of Life-Saving Moments – on its Manapakkam campus, with the aim of improving awareness of emergency preparedness and first response.

The museum was inaugurated by B. Shamoondeswari, Additional Commissioner of Police (Traffic), Greater Chennai Police. She also launched a pock-



B. Shamoondeswari, Additional Commissioner of Police (Traffic), releasing the Emergency Handbook on Wednesday. M. SRINATH

et-sized 'Emergency Handbook'.

The museum traces the evolution of emergency

and trauma care in Chennai, from the early 1980s to the development of MIOT's emergency services.

Through visual exhibits, visitors are introduced to medical emergencies and provided guidance on first aid measures.

A cardio pulmonary resuscitation demonstration station enables visitors to learn and practise chest compressions using a mannequin. The museum also recognises traffic police personnel, paramedics, and citizens who helped save lives during medical emergencies. The museum will remain open from July 15 to August 15.

CENTRAL RAILWAY
SIGNALING WORK
Tender Notice No.: CR-BB-SNT-EAST -2026-82
Divisional Railway Manager (S&T), 1st Floor, Parcel Office Building, above P.F.No.14 & 15, Central Railway, Mumbai CST 400 001, for and on behalf of the President of India Invites Open tenders from the reputed contractors. **Name of work:** Signaling work in connection with interlocking of Level Crossing Gate No. 30, 31, 40 and 42A in East section of Mumbai Division.; **Approximate Cost:** Rs. 2.95 Cr.; **Date of Opening:** 03.08.2026; **EMD:** Rs 5,90,800/-; **Validity:** 60 days; **Completion Period:** 12 Months. This tender complies with Public Procurement Policy (Make in India) Order 2017, dated 15.06.2017. Complete details of tenders are available at Central Railway. Official website www.ireps.gov.in the complete tender documents can be downloaded from the website. The complete details of tenders are also available in the "Notice Board" of the Divisional Railway Manager (S&T)'s Office, Mumbai CST. DE-364
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SOUTH EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
Corrigendum - No. 1
Following corrigendum is being made in the Tender Notice No. **DRM-ENGGBSP-T-137-26-27** C/dated **28.07.2026** for work "Construction of Long Haul Loop Lines by Extension of Existing Loop Lines and/or Construction of New Railway Lines, including Formation, Bridge Extension/Construction, Blanketing and Connectivity to the Main Line for Long Haul formation/Goods Parking Operations, along with Provision of Pathways and Other Associated Civil & P.Way Works at Lohra, Rupaund, Amlai, Mauhari and Bijuri Stations, including Construction of Track Machine Siding at Amlai Station, under the Jurisdiction of Senior Divisional Engineer North of Bilaspur Division." issued by this office with date of opening 28.07.2026. **Particulars:** Tender Value As Published earlier: ₹ 42,82,21,585.08/- Now should be read as: ₹ 41,94,05,791.34/-; EMD As Published earlier: ₹ 85,64,400/- Now should be read as: ₹ 83,88,100.00/- The tender Notice and its amendment are also available at Web site of SEC Railway <https://www.ireps.gov.in>
Sr. Divl. Engineer (North) CPRI/10/289 S.E.C. Railway, Bilaspur
South East Central Railway X@secrail

Bureau for Facilitating MSMEs of Tamil Nadu (FaMeTN)
MSME Department, Government of Tamil Nadu
1st Floor, SIDCO Corporate Office Building, Thiru Vi Ka Industrial Estate, Guindy, Chennai-600032
Invites Applications for the post of **Managing Director & Chief Executive Officer** of Tamil Nadu Food Processing and Agri Export Promotion Corporation-TN APEX
Last date of receipt of application 30.7.2026 by 18:00 Hours
For details login to website: <https://www.fametrn.com/careers>
Place: Chennai Date: 16.7.2026
Bureau for Facilitating MSMEs of Tamil Nadu (FaMeTN) MSME Department, Government of Tamil Nadu 1st Floor, SIDCO Corporate Office Building, Thiru Vi Ka Industrial Estate, Guindy, Chennai-600032.
Managing Director Bureau for Facilitating MSMEs of Tamil Nadu
DIPR/ 623 /Display/2026

SOUTH WESTERN RAILWAY
Tender notice No. CAO/CN/BNC/189/2026 Dated 08-07-2026
The under signed on behalf of the president of India, invites E- Tenders for the following works:

Description of work	Approx value
Yard Arrangement at Sasulu Station between Arsikere-Hubbali for Freight Terminal Development with 2 Additional Goods and Stabling Lines including Earthwork, Platform Works, Extension of Bridge No.52, Yard Drainage, Construction of Goomty Buildings, Approach Road, Track Linking, Electrical, TRD and Allied Works. (COMPOSITE WORK). (Tender Ref. No. UBL-JRU-66)	Rs. 29,47,77,325/-
Construction of foot over Bridge (FOB) for halt station in Gadag- Holgi (GDG-HG) section (03 Nos Kudalasangama, Angadageri, Somanakatti) and subway at Honaganahalli, Padnur and Sulerjavalgi station. (Tender Ref. No. HIGA-102)	Rs. 12,00,52,931/-

Tender schedule for SBC-SA Section: Road Over bridge in lieu of LC No.41 at Km. 65/600-700 (1x36.0m Span BOW String Steel Girder) with two wheeler ROB and balance Subway work at LC-43 between Shivadi and Dharmapuri Stations including Electrical works (Composite work). (Tender Ref. No. ROB-LC-41-SBC-SA)
Last date for submission of bids : upto 15.00 Hrs on 31-07-2026
For details Log on www.ireps.gov.in.
Deputy Chief Engineer/ Construction/Works/BNC PUB/298/AZ/PRB/SWR/2026-27
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A Tamil Play by Bombay Gnanam
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Mylapore Fine Arts Club A/C 45, Musiri Subramaniam Road, Mylapore, 6b-4, (Near St. Isabel Hospital)
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8939298790, 9840356632
Sruti Presents Tomorrow (17.07.2026) BOOK LAUNCH of C. Ramakrishnan's Musicians of Kerala Chief Guest: Sangita Kalanidhi Dr T.V. Gopalakrishnan Concert: Keralaleeyam - A Tribute to Composers of Kerala Desham K.S.Vishnuve (Vocal), H.N. Bhaskar (Violin), N.C. Bharadwaj (Mridangam), Chandrasekhara Sharma (Ghatam). Time: 6:00 PM (Book Launch), 6:30 PM (Concert) Venue: The Music Academy (Mini Hall), Chennai. All Are Welcome. Concert in memory of N.Pattabhi Raman, Founder, Sruti.
Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, East Madra Street, Mylapore, Chennai-4 is conducting "Tamizh Theatre Festival 2026" from 14th July 2026 to 17th July 2026. Today: 16th July: High Tea at 6.15 pm, 6.45 pm: KNT presents "Veera". Tomorrow: 17th July: 6.45 pm: TV Varadharajan & Team presents "Sangeetha Mumoorthigal". All are Welcome.
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SRMBV Ashram - 9448488831
Discourse in Tamil by PUJY-ASRI. Ramanacharana Tirtha (Nochur) Swami from 6:30 -8:30 pm, 10th-16th July and morning 10am -11 am from 11th -16th July at Narada Gana Sabha (Main Hall), All are welcome.

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S BHAVANI, D/o, P.Ramamoorthy, W/o, G.Sundaram, DOB: 10.06.1949, residing at No. Tower 35A, Flat Vs 68, Ashiana Shubham, Melrosapuram Road, Govindapuram, Singaperumal Koil, Chengalpattu Taluk, Chengalpattu District - 603204 shall henceforth be known as S. BHAVANI RAMAMOORTHY
I, P. Vivek, son of Thiru S. Prathaban, born on 27th July 1991 (native district: Theni), residing at Old No. 8, New No. 29, 11th Street, B.V. Nagar, Nanganallur, Chennai-600 061, shall henceforth be known as P. VIVEK RAJA
I, Loganathan C S/o Chengalvarayan residing Flat No. D4F, VGN Imperia Phase-1, 3rd Main Road, VGN Mahalakshmi Nagar, Thiruvarkadu, Chennai 600077 have changed my name to Chengalvarayan Loganathan as per Documents vide Affidavit dated 14.07.2026.

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E-Tenders (<https://etenders.kerala.gov.in>) are invited for Supply of 750 ml Pet Bottles for the period from 20.07.2026 to 30.06.2027.
E-tender ID 2026_TSC_860146_1. Last Date of Submission is 17.07.2026 at 5.15 PM.
For more details contact office website.
Thiruvalla Sd/- GM (I/c) 10.07.2026

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E-tender ID 2026_TSC_860146_1. Last Date of Submission is 17.07.2026 at 5.15 PM.
For more details contact office website.
Thiruvalla Sd/- GM (I/c) 10.07.2026

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IN BRIEF

Panchayat chief belonging to TVK held for taking bribe

Youth dies as two-wheeler crashes into barricade

A college student was killed after his two-wheeler crashed into a concrete barricade in T. Nagar on Tuesday. Police said, S. Sandeep a resident of Ramakrishna Street in T. Nagar, was proceeding on his vehicle on the Anbazhagan flyover when he lost control of the vehicle and crashed into the barricade. In the impact, he sustained severe head injuries and was rushed to the Government Royapettah Hospital. However, he was declared dead. The Pondy Bazaar traffic investigation police have registered a case, and are investigating.

WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT GOVERNMENT OF JHARKHAND Office of Deputy Director (SC) Quality Control Division, Ranchi Dam Side Dhurwa, Ranchi Email-ddwrjdhr@gmail.com		
Very Short Notice Inviting Quotation/EOI Quotation Reference No-WRD/QCD/Ranchi/ NIQ-01/2026-27 Dated-..... National Competitive Bidding		
1.	Name of the Work	Annual Maintenance Contract (AMC) For Contractor Registration/renewal of (wrdreg.jharkhand.gov.in) for Water Resources Department Gov. of Jharkhand.
2.	Mode of Submission of Bids	Online through www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in
3.	Tender fee (In INR)	Rs. 5,000.00 (Rupees five Thousand only) — Online Mode through Portal.
4.	Bid Security (In INR)	Rs. 5,00,000.00 (Rupees Fifty Thousand only)—Online Mode through Portal.
5.	Time of completion	3 Years from the date of Letter of Acceptance (LOA)
6.	Publication of online Quotation/EOI Inviting	Date:17-07-2026 (17:00 HRS)
7.	Last date and Time of receipt of online Quotation	Date:25-07-2026 (17:00 HRS)
8.	Date and Time of Online Opening of bid	Date:28-07-2026 (15:30 HRS)
9.	Date, time & place of opening of bid	Office of Deputy Director (SC) Quality Control Division, Ranchi Dam Side Dhurwa, Ranchi Email-ddwrjdhr@gmail.com
10.	Name of address of E-procurement officer	Office of Deputy Director (SC) Quality Control Division, Ranchi Dam Side Dhurwa, Ranchi Email-ddwrjdhr@gmail.com Mob No - 9905512603
11.	Helpline no.	7992401434

Note:- 1. Please see details on www.jharkhandtenders.gov.in
2. Only E-quotation will be accepted
3. The Undersign reserve the right to reject/cancel the quotation without assigning the reason thereof.

Dy. Director(SC) Quality Control Division, Dam Side Dhurwa
Water Resources Department, Government of Jharkhand
PR 385010 (Water Resource)26-27"D

CPCL's Swachhata Pakhwada ends with tree plantation drive

L.V. Navaneeth, Chief Executive Officer of The Hindu Group, Rohit Kumar Agrawala, Director (Finance), CPCL, senior CPCL officials and school students participated.



BENGALURU SOUTH CITY CORPORATION

Office of the Executive Engineer, Jayanagar Division,
no.44, 18th Main Road, 39th Cross, Jayanagar 4th T Block, Bengaluru-560041.

No.EE/BSSCC/JN/TEND/06/2026-27
Date: 15.07.2026

SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION

(Two Tender Document System) (Through GoK KPP Portal only)

The Executive Engineer, Jayanagar Division, BSSCC invites tenders on behalf of the Commissioner, BSSCC from eligible contractors registered in Greater Bengaluru Authority (Bruhat Bengaluru Mahanagara Palike) or equivalent registration with CPWD/KPWD/Railways/MES or any State Government Organizations for the constructions of work detailed in the table below. Tender documents may be downloaded from GoK e-Procurement website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> The tenderers are advised to note the minimum qualification criteria specified in Clause 3 of the instructions to tenderers to qualify for award of the contract (standard document KW-3 & KW-4). Tenders must be submitted online through GoK KPP Portal on or before **16.00 Hrs. on 24.07.2026** opening of tenders will be as per the GoK KPP Portal Guidelines.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work/ Approx. value of work (Rs. in Lakh) / EMD
1	Improvements to roads, drains, culverts and other developmental works in Nakkalubande and surrounding area in Ward No. 182 Byrasandra. Approx. value of work: Rs.500.00 Lakhs . EMD: Rs.7,50,000/- . Stipulated period: 7 months .
2	Improvements to roads, drains, culverts in 5th cross road and 6th cross road at 3rd Block Jayanagara East and surrounding area in Ward No. 182 Byrasandra. Approx. value of work: Rs.99.90 Lakhs . EMD: Rs.1,99,800/- . Stipulated period: 6 months .
3	Improvements to roads, drains, culverts in 2nd cross road at 1st Block Jayanagara East and surrounding area in Ward No. 182 Byrasandra. Approx. value of work: Rs.99.90 Lakhs . EMD: Rs.1,99,800/- . Stipulated period: 6 months .
4	Developmental Works M S Building Block A and B and surrounding area in Ward No. 182 Byrasandra. Approx. value of work: Rs.99.90 Lakhs . EMD: Rs.1,99,800/- . Stipulated period: 6 months .
5	Developmental Works and Repairs to M S Building Block-A and B in Ward No. 182 Byrasandra. Approx. value of work: Rs.250.00 Lakhs . EMD: Rs.3,75,000/- . Stipulated period: 9 months .
All the above works Cost of Tender form in Rs. (Non-Refundable) inclusive of GST: As per KPP Portal.	

1. Pre-bid meeting will be held on **20.07.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. in the office of the Chief Engineer, Jayanagar Zone (Zone-1)**, BSSCC, 9th Main, 9th Cross, Jayanagar 2nd Block, Bengaluru-560011.
2. Technical bids will be opened on or after **27.07.2026 at 16.05 Hrs.**
3. Financial bids will be opened on or after **28.07.2026 at 16.05 Hrs.**
5. For details, registration and e-payment visit GoK KPP Portal website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> or contact Helpdesk at +91-9240214000/+91-9240214001/+91-806898777/+91-8046010000.

Sd/- Executive Engineer, Jayanagar Division, BSSCC

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Bullet Train to Benares

A poem by Gopi Warriar ©

"How would it feel?" a poet thought, "to face an executioners' squad?"
Not impossible with his record of revolt against wars of greed,
cash on sales of weapons clawed back from fake wars.

No great loss - this life of fraud art, flaunted celebs,
Donald's profound tweets, drum beat of magas,
and the laser heat of neo nazis at Hungary's borders.

The manufactured virus for elimination of China, the old, the black
made not by the philosopher but his namesake pharmer,
Pouchy and Peter colluding with a deep state of evil
distributing not seeds but disease
and millions of deaths for billions in profit.

Only an ancient civilisation carried out its
dharma of saving lives not for profit.
How beautiful Tulsi, eternal love of Krishna once again
helped him kill evil Shankhachuda.

Now migrants are shot on dinghies before reaching a Western shore.
The WASP media mocks their plight for not being white.

An angry Bear is provoked by Otan's calculated circus in Ukraine
more arms and missile sales, death and refugees,
trigger pulled by those whose share values dipped in years of boring peace.

In poor countries where people cheat even beggars and sell their organs,
and staff who steal gold from dead patients in hospitals,
this world and its fake saviours the Ais are a mirror of true hell.

A bullet is simply a key into the beautiful world where he belongs.
His fast train to Kasi.

"But why give credence to illegitimate authority – East or West?
A good lesson taught by Ahura Mazda in the straits.
Ha! The sorrows of a George being unable to split India into
Hindu, Muslim and Christian states! An ageless lasting culture that learnt
to live together over millennia, whatever its peoples' fates.

I would rather seek my end in Varanasi, by Shiva,
in the Ganga through Jal Samadhi, as even Rama and Krishna did.
From the harsh grip of Maya I must go back into the eternal soul,
pure infinity."

Gopi Warriar is the son of G.P. Warriar former Chairman of Indian Railways.
Published by Delhi London Poetry Foundation.
Design by Sarah Merton

Kerala seeks T.N. help to curb inter-State drug smuggling

Chennithala holds discussions with Vijay; Minister calls for coordinated efforts by southern States to eradicate drug menace; Kerala, T.N. to share information and intelligence on trafficking groups

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala met Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Wednesday and discussed the need to establish a coordinated mechanism among the five southern States to crack down on drug peddlers and combat the menace of narcotics.

Speaking to reporters at the Secretariat here, Mr. Chennithala said he apprised Mr. Vijay of the drug menace across the southern States and briefed him on ‘Operation Toofan’, the Kerala government’s anti-narcotics drive. He said the Kerala government had been successfully imple-



Joint fight: Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala with Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay in Chennai on Wednesday.

menting ‘Operation Toofan’ for the last 43 days, during which it had arrested more than 6,000 drug peddlers and registered nearly 5,500 cases.

He said the drug menace was one of the biggest issues facing not just one

State but the entire country. He said he had discussed various aspects of ‘Operation Toofan’ with Mr. Vijay and sought the Tamil Nadu government’s cooperation in nabbing those attempting to traffic drugs across the Tamil Na-

du-Kerala boundary. He said the Kerala and Tamil Nadu would work together to share information and intelligence between their police forces, and thanked Mr. Vijay for his commitment to combating drugs.

He said he had also recently met Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar to seek Karnataka’s participation in the coordinated efforts against the menace.

Further, the Home Minister said he had invited Mr. Vijay to Kerala. “Our brand ambassador is Mohanlal. So, Mr. Mohanlal and Mr. Vijay, who is the brand ambassador for Tamil Nadu, will be together in Kerala for a big function in August. He assured us that he would come,” Mr. Chennithala said.

High Court halts major functions of Kerala Waqf Board

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court has directed the Kerala State Waqf Board not to exercise any major functions, incur capital expenditure or make policy decisions without permission from the court. The judicial functions of the board must also be stopped.

The decision comes as the court found that the board had not been constituted according to the mandate of the Unified Waqf Management, Empowerment, Efficiency, and Development (UMEED) Act, 2025.

The Act requires the inclusion of two non-Muslim members and a Shia member on the board. Petitioners contended that at present there were nine members, without these

community members.

Additionally, one of the petitions challenged the appointment of CPI(M) leader K.S. Hamsa as the chairperson of the board.

‘Follow mandate’

The Division Bench said the mandate of the UMEED Act must be followed.

The State government informed the court that it was prepared to reconstitute the board in compliance with the UMEED Act after considering the various allegations regarding the board’s composition raised in a batch of public interest litigation petitions before the court.

BJP leader Shone George had challenged the lack of non-Muslim members on the board. The Assembly of Christian Trust Services had challenged the board’s constitution.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday

TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.15 HRS)

Forecast for Thursday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Bihar, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur, Mizoram, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal and Odisha. Heat wave conditions likely at isolated places over Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	5.4	33.0	27.2	Kurnool	38.0	26.4	
Ahmedabad	37.3	27.5		Lucknow	36.3	28.0	
Aizawl	9.8	32.2	21.6	Madurai	41.0	26.1	
Bengaluru	32.2	20.8		Mangaluru	0.4	30.8	24.6
Bhopal	33.6	25.2		Mumbai	0.4	32.7	27.0
Bhubaneswar	1.8	30.7	24.0	Mysuru	33.2	18.6	
Chandigarh	36.7	26.3		New Delhi	38.4	29.1	
Chennai	40.1	28.2		Patna	35.0	28.0	
Coimbatore	33.2	22.6		Port Blair	1.1	31.0	26.8
Dehradun	14.2	32.2	24.5	Prayagraj	39.4	28.0	
Gangtok	11.1	24.5	18.4	Puducherry	38.2	27.8	
Goa	33.2	26.0		Pune	31.9	22.8	
Guwahati	33.5	27.5		Raipur	0.6	34.8	26.1
Hubballi	29.0	22.0		Ranchi	30.6	23.9	
Hyderabad	35.3	26.2		Shillong	8	26.0	17.4
Imphal	2.7	32.1	22.5	Shimla	28.9	19.8	
Jaipur	35.0	28.2		Srinagar	32.0	19.0	
Kochi	30.8	26.6		Thiruvananthapuram	33.0	25.2	
Kohima	26.0	20.0		Tiruchirappalli	38.7	27.0	
Kolkata	34.1	27.4		Vijayawada	40.1	28.0	
Kozhikode	34.0	25.5		Visakhapatnam	32.8	30.0	

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	5	39	80	57	70	Orange	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Rupnagar,
Bengaluru	4	13	36	54	115	Orange	Punjab recorded an
Chennai	6	52	23	199	285	Red	overall air quality index
Delhi	13	48	28	120	285	Red	(AQI) score of 203
Hyderabad	9	15	26	39	79	Green	indicating an unhealthy
Kolkata	17	16	40	81	96	Yellow	level of pollution. In
Lucknow	7	25	62	71	66	Green	contrast, Gangtok, Sikkim
Mumbai	6	65	31	31	63	Green	recorded a healthy AQI
Pune	23	92	30	64	30	Yellow	score of 14
Visakhapatnam	—	—	—	—	—	Green	

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

With poor rain, Cauvery panel decides to wait and watch

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC), which met on Wednesday in New Delhi amid poor monsoon rains in Karnataka’s Cauvery catchment area, desisted from issuing any direction on water release to both the riparian States of Karnataka and Tamil Nadu.

The CWRC heard the arguments of both the States and decided to wait till July 28 to take stock of the situation with respect to storage, hoping that the catchment areas may receive rain by then, it is learnt.

No water: Karnataka

According to sources, Karnataka’s representatives argued that the State was not in a position to release the

required quantum of Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu as the Cauvery basin was facing water shortage.

However, the representatives from Tamil Nadu insisted that Karnataka immediately release the quantum of water as stipulated by the Supreme Court and the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal for the current period to help its farmers.

Sandeep Vellaram
IDUKKI

The Mullaperiyar Dam recorded alarmingly low water storage in July, dropping to 112.9 ft on Wednesday compared to 131.4 ft on the same day last year. This 18.5-ft deficit has been severely affecting farming activities in the bordering districts of Tamil Nadu.

It may also soon pose a threat to tourism in the Periyar Tiger Reserve (PTR) in Thekkady, as well as drinking water distribution in the Kumily and Chakkupallom panchayats.

PTR Assistant Field Director R. Lakshmi stated that boating and other tourism activities in Thekkady are currently running smoothly. “If this situation continues and the water le-

vel drops further, tourism will face disruptions,” Ms. Lakshmi said.

The low storage impacts not only Kerala but also the neighbouring districts in Tamil Nadu. Nearly 1.5 lakh acres of farmland rely on Mullaperiyar water, including 14,700 hectares in the Theni district alone. Due to the lack of water, these farmlands currently remain dry.

Kodagu homestay owner’s arrest illegal: Karnataka HC

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Observing that the fundamental rights of Indian citizens cannot be bartered away merely because the

police received a complaint from an embassy of a country, the High Court of Karnataka has declared illegal the arrest of a Kodagu homestay owner after the alleged rape of a U.S. ci-

tizen by a housekeeper at the property in April.

The court also directed the State government to pay ₹5 lakh compensation to the owner for curtailing his personal liberty by ar-

resting him illegally.

Justice M. Nagaprasanna passed the order on a petition from the owner. “By such unlawful deprivation of liberty, the petitioner was not merely detained;

he was subjected to indignity, humiliation, and the trauma that inevitably accompanies the coercive arm of the State being unleashed without lawful justification,” the court said.

GOVERNMENT OF JHARKHAND

AGRICULTURE, ANIMAL HUSBANDRY & CO-OPERATIVE DEPARTMENT
(CO-OPERATIVE DIVISION)

OFFICE OF THE REGISTRAR, CO-OPERATIVE SOCIETIES JHARKHAND, RANCHI

INTEGRATED CO-OPERATIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECT (I.C.D.P.) CELL, RANCHI

Short e-Tender Notice

DATE:- 15.07.2026

SL No.	Tender Notice Number	Name of work	No Of Unit	Estimated Value of Work (in Rs)	Cost Of BoQ (in Rs)	Earnest Money (in Rs)	Time Of Completion Of Work
01.	ICDP/RANCHI/25/2026-27	Construction of 500 MT Capacity Godown in Lamps/Pacs Of Districts HAzaribagh, Chatra, Bokaro & Deoghar	21	19,95,78,900.00	10,000.00	19,96,000.00	12 Months
02.	ICDP/RANCHI/26/2026-27	Construction of 500 MT Capacity Godown in Lamps/Pacs Of Districts Palamu & Garhwa.	11	8,78,14,716.00	10,000.00	8,78,500.00	12 Months
05.	Date Of Publication of on Website	20.07.2026 AT 11:00 AM					
06.	Last Date & Time of Submission of bids	25.07.2026 AT 05:00 PM					
07.	Name & Address of Office Inviting Tender	State Monitoring Officer, ICDP Cell, Ranchi, Pasupalan-Sahkarita Bhawan Singh More, Hesag, Hatia, Ranchi. 834003					
08.	Contact No of Procurement Officer	7979780612, 9931477485					
06.	Bid document with details terms and conditions will be available online on e-tendering portal, http://Jharkhandtenders.gov.in from 20.07.2026 at 11:00 AM to 25.07.2026 up to 05:00 PM. Bids must be Submitted online only at the e- tendering portal http:// Jharkhandtender.gov.in on or before 05:00 PM on 25.07.2026. Tender Fee and EMD Will be received through online mode only. Bidders can use internet banking facility for faster processing of tender fee and EMD. Alternatively, bidders can use NEFT/RTGS challan generated for the tender from Jharkhandtenders.gov.in portal. Technical Bid received online will be opened at 05:00 PM on 27.07.2026.						
07.	Estimate Cost May Vary.						
08.	Corrigendum/Amendment if any will be published only on the above mentioned website.						Sd/-
PR 385048 (Co-opretive) 26-27 (D)							State monitoring Officer ICDP Cell, Ranchi

NATIONAL HIGHWAYS AUTHORITY OF INDIA

PIU –SALEM

Office: No. Door No.212-3/D3-1, Sri Nagar Colony, Narasothipatti, Salem - 636 004.
Phone No. 0427 - 2444275, Mail id: nhaisalem1@gmail.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

The public is hereby informed that the Central Government, in the Ministry of Road Transport & Highways vide the Notification S.O. 2842 (E) published in Gazette of India No. 2748 dated 03.06.2026 has authorized the NHAI to collect the user fee from the road users from 0/800 to Km.57/800 in Cuddalore to Vriddhachalam Section of NH-532 of Toll Plaza located at Km.45/200 (U.Ponnalagaram) under the powers conferred by Sec 7 of NH Act 1956 (Act 48/1956) read with the NH fee (Determination of Rates and Collection) Rules 2008 rates specified in Column 3,4,5 & 6 of the following table on the type of vehicles specified in Col. 2 thereof with effect from the 00:00 Hrs on 20.07.2026.

Sl.No.	Type of Vehicles	Fee for single Journey (in rupees)	Fee for Return Journey within a day (in rupees)	Fee for monthly pass for 50 single journeys in a month (in rupees)	Fee for single journey for the commercial vehicles registered within the district of Toll Plaza (in rupees)
1	Car, Jeep, Van or Light Motor Vehicle	95	140	3095	45
2	Light Commercial Vehicle, Light Goods Vehicle or Mini Bus	150	225	5000	75
3	Bus or Truck (Two Axes)	315	470	10475	155
4	Three -Axle commercial vehicles	345	515	11425	170
5	Heavy Construction Machinery (HCM) or Earth Moving Equipment (EME) or Multi-Axle Vehicle (MAV) (four to six axles)	495	740	16425	245
6	Oversized Vehicles (seven or more axles)	600	900	19995	300

Note: - The rate of monthly pass applicable for local personal vehicle shall be Rs. 350/- (Rupees Three hundred and fifty only) for the year 2026-27. Monthly Pass Road users who require can be obtained from the Administrative office at Toll Plaza.

DGM (T) Cum Project Director
National Highways Authority of India, Project Implementation Unit, Salem
Building a Nation, Not Just Roads

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

SHRI K.R. Balasubramanian (Retd. IA & AS) 90 Yrs passed away on 11.07.2026 at home, Nanganallur Chennai. Deeply mourned by : K B Vaidyanathan & K B Muralidharan (Sons), Sathyabama Thyagarajan (Daughter), Daughters-in-law, Son-in-law and Grandchildren. Ph 9952029774

Mr.Y.LAKSHMI NARAYAN (87) Father of Mr. Y. Krishna, Chennai - 600017, expired on 15-07-2026, Eyes donated to Rotary Rajan Eye Bank (Project of Rotary Club of Madras T.Nagar), Chennai-17 (Ph: 28340500).

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

1st ANNIVERSARY

K. RAMANAN FCA
(Founder K. Ramanan & Co, Chartered accountants)
Born: 12th October 1949
Reached heavenly abode on: 16th July 2025
Remembering every moment with lots of love in our hearts.
Wife/Son/Daughter/ grand daughter and staff.
Fondly remembered by Son: Ajoy Ramanan 98408 19391

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES

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DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

51st Year Remembrance
In Fond Loving Memory of our Beloved Founder

Late Shri Batchu Purushottam Garu
12.09.1901 to 16.07.1975
From Family Members, Partners & Staff
M/s.B.Purushottam & Co.,
Chartered Accountants

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

10th YEAR ANNIVERSARY

Mrs. Vijayalakshmi Sankaran
(Ex. Assistant Manager RBI)
IN LOVING MEMORY
Shekher & Mythili Shekher

SIXTH ANNIVERSARY

Mr. L.SANTHANAM
DOB: 01.01.1963 - DOD:16.07.2020
"You are the light of our life"
DEARLY MISSED BY
Family and Friends

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

SECOND DEATH ANNIVERSARY

Date of Birth 26-SEP-1930 Date of Death 16-JUL-2024

Shri. N. K. Kondalswamy Naidu

In Loving Memory of Our King

While we mourn your absence every day, we also celebrate a life well lived. Beneath the strict and disciplined exterior was a kind heart, a spirited soul, and one of the most grounded men we have ever known. You will forever remain our guiding light.

May you rest in eternal peace. You will always be loved, deeply respected, and never forgotten.

Fondly missed by Family and friends
Management and staff
Fortel Hotel
Chennai -8

The crisis at the heart of non-proliferation

The present impasse over Iran’s nuclear future lays bare the enduring hypocrisy at the heart of the global non-proliferation order. As talks in Doha stumble through disputes over frozen assets and verification mechanisms, Tehran is being pressed to accept full dismantlement of its enriched uranium stockpile in exchange for economic compensation for decades of sanctions, even as President Masoud Pezeshkian insists Iran will not relinquish its sovereign right to enrich uranium. The demand is unambiguous. Yet the five recognised weapons powers, and Israel, undeclared but widely known to possess the bomb, face no comparable ultimatum to disarm.

The current confrontation raises an unavoidable question: on what grounds should Iran relinquish a capability that nine nuclear states retain for themselves? The claim that Iran is uniquely dangerous, unstable, or aggressive is a conclusion in search of evidence, and cloaked in language by states whose own commitment to international law is selective at best.

Unequal rules
The Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons (NPT) institutionalised a hierarchy rather than dismantling it. It divided the world into nuclear “haves” and “have-nots,” and enjoined the latter to restraint while the former continue to modernise their nuclear arsenals. Against this backdrop, the treatment of Iran is not an anomaly. India and Pakistan, both outside the NPT, possess substantial nuclear arsenals and are welcomed as strategic partners by the very powers that patrol the non-proliferation order. Israel, whose nuclear programme is an open secret, has never submitted to inspection and is never named in the discourse of proliferation risk. Iran, by contrast, pursued enrichment within a legal



Shelley Wallia
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The Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons institutionalised a hierarchy rather than dismantling it

framework, submitted to the most intrusive inspection regime in the history of arms control under the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), and was “rewarded” with unilateral American withdrawal, the reimposition of sanctions, and the renewed threat of military destruction. Iran complied and got punished anyway.

There is a deeper historical contradiction that the current discourse labours to suppress. The global nuclear order is, in a fundamental sense, anchored in an act of unparalleled destruction of Hiroshima and Nagasaki in August 1945. These remain the only instances in history of nuclear weapons being deployed in conflict. They established the catastrophic potential of such arms as well as the precedent that their use could be justified, and absorbed into the language of strategic necessity by the state that employed them. The U.S. survived this act morally, emerging successfully as the designated guardian of nuclear order.

This precedent complicates every subsequent moral claim. A state that has demonstrated the willingness to use nuclear weapons against civilian populations occupies a singular position when it seeks to regulate the ambitions of others. The authority it claims is derived from the fact of prior use, and from the geopolitical dominance that use helped to consolidate. Albert Einstein warned with characteristic precision that humanity must choose between abolishing war and facing annihilation. That choice stands only deferred, and most effectively by those with the largest arsenals.

The unravelling of the JCPOA remains one of the most instructive episodes in recent diplomatic history, precisely because it was so revealing. Negotiated painstakingly under the Barack Obama administration, the agreement represented a genuinely achieved instance of multilateral diplomacy. Its

abandonment by the Donald Trump administration in 2018 sent a message that resonated far beyond Tehran. For any state observing this trajectory, the conclusion inescapably underscores that future arms agreements with the U.S. carry no guarantee of American compliance. It must be kept in mind that if the Iran nuclear crisis deepens further, the JCPOA’s destruction will stand as its proximate cause.

An enduring paradox
The question, in the end, is not whether Iran should or should not enrich uranium. It is whether the framework within which that question is posed is coherent, consistent, or just. By any honest reckoning, it is none of these things. Until that framework is confronted directly, and not obscured by the language of non-proliferation, the contradictions at the heart of the nuclear age will continue to compound. The answer to that question has been available since 1955, when Einstein and Bertrand Russell unambiguously asserted that nuclear weapons must be abolished altogether, by all states, without exception, or the logic of deterrence will produce the catastrophe it claims to prevent. Seven decades later, that conclusion remains as sound as ever.

We stand at a crossroads in a world that has grown accustomed to the gun on the table, until the day it goes off. Selective enforcement of non-proliferation, punishing Iran for compliance while rewarding others for defiance, and the indefinite deferral of the NPT’s disarmament obligation do not constitute a rules-based order. They constitute a system that has chosen, knowingly, to tolerate the most destructive weapons in history rather than eliminate them. That choice carries a cost. The only question is whether we confront it through policy or through catastrophe.

Revelling in the power of visual politics

How image and digital strategy power Tamil Nadu CM Vijay’s politics

STATE OF PLAY

B. Kolappan

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay is a man of few words, say those who have met him in person. He prefers to listen rather than speak. He is perhaps the only major political leader in the State who has consistently avoided the media and has not held a press conference since launching the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) throughout his election campaign or even after assuming office as Chief Minister.

It is not that he is incapable of engaging in political discourse. When he is thoroughly prepared and rises to address the Assembly or a public meeting, he is capable of delivering speeches, often launching sharp attacks on his political adversaries. Of course, it is peppered with colloquial words and usages that may appeal to his film fans but would make some squirm. Mr. Vijay appears acutely aware that, whether he speaks sparingly or at length, every word serves a political purpose. This marks a striking transformation of a film actor who chose to remain silent in the aftermath of the Karur stampede at his rally last year.

Digital dominance
A close observer of social media will notice how virtually anything connected with the Chief Minister goes viral within minutes. The TVK’s well-organised digital machinery amplifies posts relating to Mr. Vijay across multiple platforms, ensuring they reach a vast audience. He has nearly 8,97,000 followers on X through his official TVK account and about 2.3 million followers on his Chief Minister’s account on Instagram.



ter’s account and 4.1 million followers on Instagram.

Critical comments about Mr. Vijay or his government often trigger swift rebuttals from his supporters, while the Opposition just as quickly contests praise for the Chief Minister. The resulting online exchanges are often intense, underscoring Mr. Vijay’s large-than-life presence in the digital sphere. The phenomenon extends well beyond social media. Media reports on the Chief Minister – even routine accounts of the functions he attends – generate unusual public interest. His political persona has created a level of engagement rarely witnessed in Tamil Nadu politics, signalling a new phase in the interaction between politics, traditional media and social media.

One of the highest-paid actors before entering politics, Mr. Vijay built his cinematic career largely on films that projected him as an invincible hero. That image has proved to be a political asset in Tamil Nadu, where cinema and politics have long shared an intimate relationship.

Even the Leader of the Opposition, Udhayanidhi Stalin, acted in films before entering active politics, recognising cinema’s unparalleled ability to build public visibility. However, almost all their predecessors combined their film careers with gradual political involvement over many years.

Mr. Vijay’s trajectory has been remarkably different. He announced his decision to launch a political party, formally established the TVK, campaigned across Tamil Nadu, contested the Assembly election and became Chief Minister – all within an extraordinarily short span of time.

Such a rapid ascent to the highest elected office is without precedent in the history of the Dravidian movement. It marks the emergence of a leader who converted immense cinematic popularity into political power with remarkable speed.

As Chief Minister, he has adapted the art of commanding public attention, honed during his years as a film actor, to the realm of politics. When he flagged off vehicles of the health department, he took the wheel himself for a short distance, sitting alongside commuters while launching buses. The video clip achieved what a costly advertising campaign or a lengthy government press release could scarcely have accomplished. When chess grandmaster R. Praggnanandhaa called on him, a chessboard had been arranged in advance and the two played a few moves, producing another widely shared visual. On another occasion, while visiting the Nemmeli desalination plant, he drank a glass of the purified water before the cameras. Later, while launching a public distribution initiative, he briefly assumed the role of a ration shop salesman.

Whether spontaneously or carefully choreographed, such visual moments have demonstrated Mr. Vijay’s instinctive understanding of the power of political imagery in the age of social media. He revels in the power of visual politics.

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How challenging will Delhi’s ambitious EV transition be?

Delhi’s target of registering only EV three-wheelers from 2027 seems achievable, but the path to same for two-wheelers from 2028 is likely to be bumpier

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani

The Government of the National Capital Territory of Delhi has given a firm push towards transition to electric vehicles through its new Delhi Electric Vehicles Policy, 2026, notified on June 30.

The policy has set aggressive deadlines for three-wheelers, light commercial vehicles such as mini trucks and two-wheelers. Only EVs in the first two categories can be registered from January 1, 2027, with the deadline for two-wheelers set at January 1, 2028.

Though the policy is right in aiming high, considering Delhi’s pollution problem that is worsening every year, analysis shows that it could be an onerous challenge to meet these targets, especially for two-wheelers.

According to the Commission for Air Quality Management’s latest source-apportionment study, transport continues to be the largest source of particulate pollution during winter (23%), besides contributing to secondary particulate matter (**Table 1**).

Noting that two-wheelers account for nearly 67% of Delhi’s vehicle fleet, the policy says their “rapid electrification [is] critical for achieving meaningful reductions in vehicular emissions”. For three-wheelers and goods carriers in the category of light commercial vehicles, the policy says they exhibit high daily utilisation and mileage, “resulting in a disproportionate contribution to urban air pollution”.

The two segments are, however, at different stages of the transition to electric mobility. Three-wheelers account for only four per cent of the total vehicles in Delhi and 43.16% of them are already electric (**Table 2**).

New registration of three-wheelers is seeing an even further jump towards EVs. Of the 12,809

new three-wheelers registered till the first week of July this year, 8,419 were electric (65.7%).

The picture is markedly different for two-wheelers. Of the roughly 1.05 crore two-wheelers on Delhi’s roads, only 1.7% are EVs. In new registrations as well, two-wheelers are showing only marginal improvements.

Moreover, Delhi is not switching to EV two-wheelers at a noticeably faster rate than the country at the moment, for the rapid transition it is targeting by the end of 2027 (**Chart 1**).

The number of two-wheelers getting registered in Delhi every year shows the massive leap needed in sales. Of the 5.68 lakh two-wheelers registered in 2025-26, only 41,263 (7.25%) were EVs (**Chart 2**).

Even with a conservative assumption that the demand for new two-wheelers and consequently the two-wheeler registrations will remain at the same level, the sale of EV two-wheelers should see at least a twelve-fold (1300%) jump by next year if the policy’s target has to be met by January 1, 2028.

The real challenge would be even more arduous since the registration of two-wheelers is increasing significantly year-on-year. For instance, the numbers went up by nearly 25% between 2024-25 (4.56 lakh) and 2025-26 (5.68 lakh).

The problem would be compounded further if Delhi decides to implement the end-of-life policy for vehicles strictly, as it would demand petrol and diesel-fuelled two-wheelers that are respectively 15 and 10 years old to be replaced with EVs.

The effective implementation of the EV policy will also require Delhi to ramp up the availability of support infrastructure. Delhi Transco Limited has been tasked with expanding public charging facilities.

Delhi presently has 771 charging points, which are unevenly distributed and highly concentrated in the southern region (**Chart 3**).

Power shift

The data for charts were sourced from VAHAN, India Climate and Energy Dashboard, and the Department of Transport, Delhi



TABLE 1: This shows the major contributors to Delhi’s pollution during summer and winter

Sector	Winter (%)	Winter range (%)	Summer (%)	Summer range (%)
Transport	23	19–24	19	18–21
Industry	9	8–10	14	9–15
Dust	15	10–18	27	25–31
Biomass burning	20	17–23	12	11–14
Secondary particulate matter	27	24–28	17	16–19
Other sources	6	–	11	–

Note: Biomass burning, includes burning of municipal solid waste and crop-residue burning. Secondary particulate matter include those transformed from gaseous emissions from transport, industries, biomass burning, etc

TABLE 2: This shows the total number of two, three and four-wheelers in Delhi as of July 6, 2026 as per VAHAN database

Vehicle type	EV	Gas-based	Petrol / diesel	Others	Total	% of total	% of EV
Two-wheelers	1,80,368	6,269	1,03,22,284	2,188	1,05,11,109	67.5	1.72
Three-wheelers	2,68,114	2,80,488	71,857	781	6,21,240	4	43.16
Four-wheelers	43,102	8,21,692	34,29,079	1,36,690	44,30,563	28.5	0.97

CHART 2: This shows the EV and other types of two-wheelers registered every year in Delhi (2011-26)

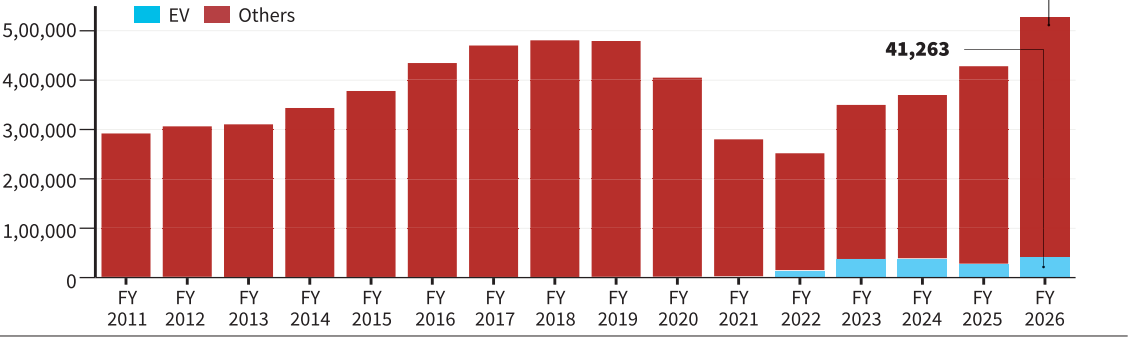


CHART 1: Share of electric vehicles in two-wheelers registered every year in the last decade

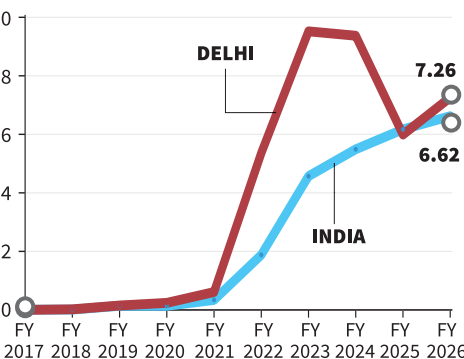
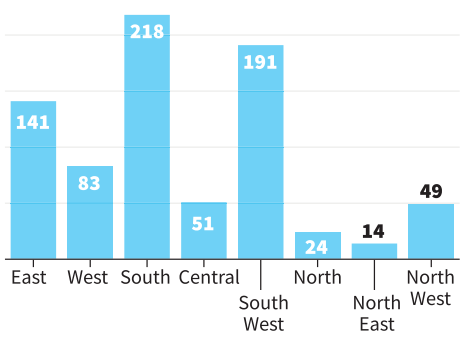


CHART 3: Public charging points across districts in Delhi as per www.ev.delhi.gov.in



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 16, 1976

They give life to ‘dead’ letters

Madras: Letter writing may be an art where imagination can take wings, but addressing the letters calls for care and precision. Otherwise, a letter meant for a girl with a secret dream could well find its way to the Returned Letter Office.

Once known as the Dead Letter Office, it has been quietly doing its work right from the days Lord Clive introduced the “Official Postal System” in 1766.

Of the 15 RLOs in the country, Calcutta is the oldest, but Madras is one of the busiest (receiving articles from both the Indian and Pacific Ocean nations). To this office, letters come at the rate of 156 a day. The Circle handles about 65 crores of letters annually.

Over 80 persons in this office do a job which should strike a visitor as most amusing (and, of course, most useful). These dedicated men and women, divided into eight or nine linguistic sections give life to letters which must be deemed ‘dead’ for all purposes.

Within 48 hours of the letters coming to the central table, where Mr. D. Sivaramiah, Manager, sits, they are distributed to the appropriate sections – English, Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Malayalam, Tamil, Telugu and Urdu. These men and women, some by instinct and others by sheer experience, and all of them with a uncanny sixth sense, decipher the hieroglyphics and “revitalise” the lost letters. Most of them have come as being “undecipherable”, “unclaimed”, “refused”, or “left with insufficient address”.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 16, 1926

Govt’s scheme published

Simla, July 15: In pursuance of the Lee Recommendations, the Government of India with the approval of the Secretary of State, have framed a scheme for the recruitment and the training of officers for the three main departments of railways:—(1) Transportation (Traffic) and commercial, (2) Civil Engineering and (3) Mechanical Engineering and transportation (power). The object of the schemes is to see that recruitment in India is advanced, as soon as practicable, up to 75 per cent of the total number of vacancies in the superior railway services. The outlines of the scheme are published.

From Page One

Iran warns of blockade over U.S. actions

“As tensions flare again in the Strait of Hormuz, that room [from oil surplus] is now smaller and shrinking further as spare capacity has been deployed, demand has compressed, and inventories have been drawn down,” Azim Sadikov and Jean-Marc Natal from the IMF wrote in a blog post. “Unless inventories are replenished, the world will start from a weaker position when the next shock comes.”

At the heart of the resumption of hostilities has been the dispute over the Strait of Hormuz, a waterway that is crucial for global oil and gas flows.

Iran blockaded Hormuz after the U.S. and Israel launched their massive attack on February 28, using it for leverage against its foes for months before briefly reopening it, and then again vowing it would be closed “until the U.S. ends its aggression”.

The U.S., in turn, has reimposed its own blockade of Iran’s ports, though Mr. Trump has backed down on a planned 20% levy on ships using the strait.

Since the war began, Iran has asserted its control over the strait and opened fire on ships for taking routes it says are unauthorised.

“The retaliatory operations of the fighters will continue, and the strait will remain closed until the U.S. ends its acts of aggression,” the Guards have said.

Recent escalations

A Norwegian tanker was hit by an explosion caused by an unidentified defence off the Omani coast early on Tuesday, the crisis response company MTI Network said.

Kuwait said one of its naval vessels was struck during an Iranian missile and drone barrage, wounding four crew members.

Since last week, renewed U.S. attacks have killed at least 30 people in Iran, a government spokesperson said. Separately, the military announced that seven of its personnel were killed in Wednesday’s strikes on the southeast.

Kudankulam plant data leak sparks ‘commotion’

The leak originated from a server hosted by third party provider Yotta. The plant’s contractor, Anil Ambani’s Reliance Group, has admitted that a “partial breach” had happened and the government had been informed.

“Suspicious activity on Yotta’s server was noted on May 29 last and it was reported in June-end. Investigations by Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited, the project proponent, and Computer Emergency Response Team are on,” the sources said.

Reliance Group’s Reliance Infrastructure bagged the contract in 2018 to build infrastructure for reactors 3 and 4, both under construction.

When the KKNPP encountered a similar incident in 2019, wherein a North Korean malware infection on its administrative network exposed the plant’s vulnerability, NPCIL had dismissed it saying that their “unbreachable standalone network” was intact and no data could be accessed by any dark web.

Neither KKNPP’s site director Ashok Bhatiya, nor V.P. Sunil, Station Director (1 and 2), could be reached for their comments on this sensitive issue.

The senior manager of human resources and public relations Kannan, who would usually be in touch with the media for occasional press statements, also did not pick up repeated calls.

SC refuses to entertain plea to curb social media content

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday refused to entertain a writ petition to curb podcasts and social media reels, saying the freedom allowed to citizens to approach the court under Article 32 of the Constitution for enforcement of their fundamental rights cannot be used as a ruse to politicise issues.

The court was hearing a petition against the online circulation of allegedly derogatory comments posted by an influencer against Prophet Muhammad.

The Bench said the petitioner should ideally file a complaint in such cases. The petitioner’s counsel said that the plea was highlighting the need for curbs against abusive or hurtful social media posts. Justice P.S. Narasimha said the issue raised was not a case for an Article 32 petition.

Congress asks Centre to clarify on U.S. Bill seeking 100% tariffs

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Wednesday asked Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal to clarify the Centre’s position after a bipartisan group of United States Senators introduced a Bill proposing 100% tariffs on imports from India and four other countries for continuing to purchase Russian oil.

The proposed legislation, initiated by Republican Senator late Lindsey Graham, seeks to impose punitive tariffs on India, China, Slovakia, Hungary and Azerbaijan.

European exemption

It exempts 15 European nations that continue to import Russian gas, arguing that such imports account for only a small share of their energy needs and that they are reducing their dependence on Moscow.

EC revises phase 3 SIR schedule for four States

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission of India (EC) on Wednesday revised the schedule of the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls for Karnataka, Delhi, Telangana, and Punjab, extending it by around 10-12 days. These States are among the 16 States and Union Territories where the third phase of the SIR is going on.

In Karnataka, the house-to-house visits will now end on August 8 instead of July 29. The draft electoral rolls will be published on August 17 instead of August 8, and the final voter list will be published on September 18 instead of September 7.

In Telangana and Punjab, the enumeration phase has been extended to August 3 from July 24. The draft rolls will be published on August 10 as against July 31, and the final list will come out on October 12 instead of October 1.

In Delhi, the final voters’ list will now be published on October 19 and draft electoral rolls will come out on August 17 instead of August 5. The house-to-house visits scheduled till July 29 will now continue till August 8.

Assam Rifles camp attacked, vehicles torched in Manipur

Violence occurred after paramilitary forces launched search operations close to an NSCN (I-M) camp, a Defence spokesperson said; residents stopped patrol columns from entering villages

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

A mob threw stones, vandalised an Assam Rifles camp and damaged four vehicles of the security forces in Senapati town of Manipur around 9.30 p.m. on Tuesday.

The attack occurred after the paramilitary forces launched an area domination patrol and search operation based on “credible intelligence inputs” regarding the presence of armed cadres in Makuilongdi, about 2 km west of a designated camp of the NSCN (I-M) at Oklong.

The NSCN (I-M) refers to the Isak-Muivah faction of the National Socialist Council of Nagaland. The outfit prefers to call itself the National Socialist Council of Nagalim.

“The intelligence reports and social media posts indicated the presence of armed cadres moving outside designated camps, carrying weapons and wearing uniforms, in violation of established Ceasefire Ground Rules,” the Defence spokesperson said on Wednesday.

The Ceasefire Monitor-



Tensions boil over: Charred remains of a vehicle following a mob attack in Senapati district of Manipur on Wednesday. PTI

ing Group, which observes, verifies, and reports on compliance with agreed pauses in fighting, was formally informed regarding the reported violations, highlighting the security concerns, he said.

Entry stand-off

“During the course of the operation, residents, including women, obstructed the Assam Rifles columns approaching Makuilongdi and Oklong villages. The columns exercised maximum restraint

and communicated with the local representatives, adding that the operations were aimed solely at ensuring security and maintaining peace in the area, and that the columns would not enter any village without the consent of the authorities,” the spokesperson said.

As tensions escalated, a large crowd gathered in Senapati town around 9 p.m. and prepared to march towards the Assam Rifles at Naga Taphou in the district. “Despite the withdra-

BSF initiates technical study as plan to fence challenging Sundarbans terrain gathers pace

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

In a first, the Union Home Ministry is set to fence about 90 kilometres of the Sundarbans along the India-Bangladesh border in West Bengal, a challenging terrain characterised by mangrove forests, tidal swamps, embankments, and numerous creeks.

The Border Security Force (BSF), which is deployed along the Bangladesh border, has initiated a feasibility and technical study to erect the fence along the land border with Bangladesh, a senior government official told *The Hindu*. At present, there are no barriers on the ground and the BSF has de-



Ground work: BSF Director-General Praveen Kumar interacting with people in the Sundarbans. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ployed Floating Border Outposts, or FBOPs, in the riverine areas to secure the border. Plans are afoot to augment marine patrolling, the official said.

Praveen Kumar, Direc-

tor-General, BSF, had visited the Sundarbans from July 11 to 14 and reviewed the progress of the fencing work. “No fencing work has ever been done in the Sundarbans till now. The

locals have been counselled that fencing is a requirement and that it is vital for national security. The joint inspection by the BSF and Department of Irrigation will start soon,” said the official.

Protected area

As part of a public outreach, the BSF D-G met with local people and government officials in the area, a BSF statement said.

Almost 71 km of the border is contiguous with the Sundarbans Wildlife Sanctuary where no construction work is allowed as it is a protected area, the official said. “The three-day security review led by the D-G focused on time-bound completion of fence-relat-

ed work. The need for more searchlights and surveillance cameras to aid marine domination was discussed,” said the official.

Another official said that people were concerned about their land being acquired for construction of the fence. “Several mid-scale hotels and lodges which operate in the area also raised concern. They have been assured that the government will compensate and rehabilitate them,” said the official.

“Though the Sundarbans is not a preferred route for infiltrators, it is used for trans-border crimes. After August 2024, additional security measures were taken up here,” said the official.

SC raps panel mandated to protect people from NE States

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday questioned if any concrete work is being done by the court-mandated monitoring committee set up to address problems faced by people from the northeastern States living across the country, including racial discrimination and targeted violence.

Justice Sanjay Kumar asked if the committee’s meetings were only meant to “consume cups of tea”. “All talk, nothing seems to be done,” Justice Kumar said.

The court’s oral observations were triggered when records submitted by the government referred to how the whereabouts of a woman who had sent a complaint to the committee remained a mystery. Justice Kumar asked how the woman could remain untraceable with no means of communication, given that she had emailed her grievance to the committee.

The panel was formed to “monitor, oversee, pursue and review” the implementation of the M.P. Bezbaruah Committee report of July 2014 following the death of Nido Tania, a 19-year-old student from Arunachal Pradesh, in Delhi.

ED files PMLA complaint in alleged visa fraud racket

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has filed a prosecution complaint against Red Leaf Immigration Private Limited and others in connection with an alleged organised immigration and visa fraud under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

Among those named are Amandeep Singh, Poonam Rani, Ankur Kumar Kehar, Nitin Vij, Kamaljit Kansal, Overseas Partner, and Rudra Consultancy Services.

The ED initiated its probe based on multiple FIRs filed by police, following complaints by the U.S. Embassy in New Delhi.

Rath Yatra is Puri’s most spectacular festival: President

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

As Odisha prepares for the annual Rath Yatra, which begins in Puri on July 16, President Droupadi Murmu has shared a rare and deeply personal account of her lifelong devotion to Lord Jagannath, describing how her faith sustained her through personal hardships and continues to guide her in public life.

The President said that Lord Jagannath’s message of equality has always guided her own commitment to serving all sections of society. She said she silently prayed to Lord Jagannath while proceeding to Parliament to take the oath of office on July 25, 2022.

“I prayed to Mahaprabhu: ‘You are taking me to such lofty heights. I implore You to guide me at every step and always be with me. He listened to my prayer. He always res-



Droupadi Murmu

ponds to my prayers,” said the President.

Describing the Rath Yatra as the most spectacular among the many festivals celebrated in Puri, Ms. Murmu noted that it is the one occasion when Lord Jagannath, accompanied by Lord Balabhadra, Devi Subhadra and Sudarshana, leaves the sanctum of the temple to travel in majestic chariots along the Bada Danda to the Gundicha Temple, giving devotees an opportunity to have darshan outside the shrine.

(Full article is at [newsth.live/puri](https://www.newsth.live/puri))

NDA renews push to muster numbers for delimitation Bill

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde reportedly met Union Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi on Wednesday. FILE PHOTO

Panel defers final meeting on higher education Bill amid objections from A.P.



A Parliamentary panel led by BJP MP D. Purandeswari is reviewing the Bill. FILE PHOTO

Wangchuk loses 8.9 kg as fast for Pradhan's resignation continues

Wife says activist's decision to join CJP protest was organic

Plea in Delhi HC seeks steps to save Sonam Wangchuk

Mamata comes to Abhishek's defence, says he is still fighting

A portrait of a woman with dark hair, wearing large black-rimmed glasses and a white scarf with blue stripes. She is looking slightly to the right. The background is a blurred outdoor scene with a colorful circular object.

Mamata Banerjee

Faction led by Ritabrata gets more time to file response

Madan Mitra leaves Mamata, joins rebel Trinamool faction

ଓଡ଼ିଶା ବିଦ୍ୟୁତ୍ ଶକ୍ତି ସଂଚାରଣ ନିଗମ ଲିଡ଼

(ଓଡ଼ିଶା ସରକାରଙ୍କ ଏକ ଉପକ୍ରମ)

Regd. Office: OPTCL Tech Tower, Janpath, Saheed Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751007



ODISHA POWER TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LIMITED

(A Government of Odisha Undertaking)

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

E-Tender No.	Tender Description:	Estimated Cost
CPC-42/2026-27	Procurement of Hardware fittings & accessories for various conductor as per triennial procurement plan of O&M materials for the FY 2026-27 in e-tendering mode only. Last Date & Time of Submission of Bid: 13.08.2026 upto 12:30 Hr.	Rs. 3,19,73,220/-
CPC-53/2026-27	Lot-I: Design, Engineering, Supply, Installation and Testing & Commissioning for: "Upgradation of 132/33kV GSS Palaspanga to 220/132/33kV GIS S/s with construction of 220 kV D/C line from proposed 400/220 kV GSS at Unchabali to proposed 220/132kV GIS at Palaspanga with 02 Nos. of 220kV feeder bay extensions at Unchabali GSS" on Turnkey contract basis. Lot-II: Design, Engineering, Supply, Installation and Testing & Commissioning for: "Upgradation of 132/33kV Grid S/s Barbil to 220/132/33 kV GSS Barbil (220 kV Side GIS) along with construction of 220 kV D/C line on 400 kV tower (Twin Moose conductor) from Barbil GIS to proposed 400/220 kV GSS at Unchabali" on Turnkey contract basis. Last Date & Time of Submission of Bid: 11.08.2026 upto 11:00 A.M.	Rs. 3,15,26,872/-

Complete set of bidding documents are available at www.tenderwizard.com/OPTCL and www.optcl.co.in.

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✉ /optcl_odisha
HIPR-41/2026-27



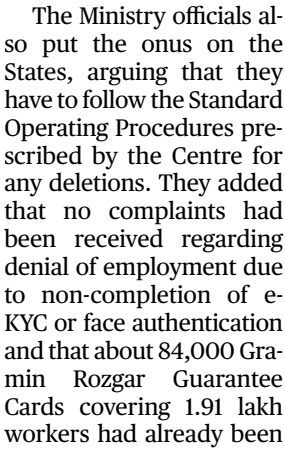
Two law students held for disrupting SC proceedings

In meeting with House panel, Ladakh villagers seek access to grazing lands along the LAC

The 15-member delegation, representing the border villages of Maan Pangong A and B, Leh, Ladakh, requested that nomadic pastoralists be permitted controlled access to India's traditional grazing lands in coordination with security agencies, emphasising that the continued presence of local communities in these frontier regions contributes significantly to the region's

“The nomads of the border villages depend on these grazing grounds to rear their livestock. Whenever they go there, the Army stops them. We are not even allowed to bring loose earth from these no-go zones to build our huts, and collecting firewood is also not permitted. Before May 2020, we had free access to these areas,” Mr. Stanzin, who briefed the parliamentary panel, told *The Hindu*.

‘Dynamic figure’
Rural Development Ministry officials, however, disputed the findings, saying the analysis covered only a short period and did not reflect the continuous veri-



The group said that although transition guidelines provided that e-KYC-verified MGNREGA Job Cards would remain valid and workers should not be denied employment because of pending e-KYC, there was little clarity on how workers unable to com-

The organisation noted that publicly available data do not indicate why workers were removed, whether they had pending e-KYC or facial recognition verification, whether prior notice was issued, whether Gram Sabha verification was conducted or whether an appeal mechanism was available. It also does not reveal the gender, age or caste of those affected.

The court was hearing a petition filed by Rakesh Binjola, represented by advocate Laxmikant Matadan Shukla, seeking a fair and reasonable inquiry into the “patent irregularities” found in the OSM evalua-

The top law officer said the government was not taking the court's intervention on an adversarial note, and agreed to file the status report by July 24.

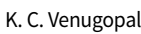
Mr. Binjola said the OSM system had been implemented for the first time without giving the evaluators any formal training.

"In May, Modiji preached the entire country to save, and then his government imposed levies and burned up the public's savings! West Asia War is just an excuse; the truth is that in the last 12 years, the BJP has built a dubious record of picking the public's

In a post on X, he said the increase reflected mounting economic stress, and claimed the Congress had repeatedly warned the government about the trend.

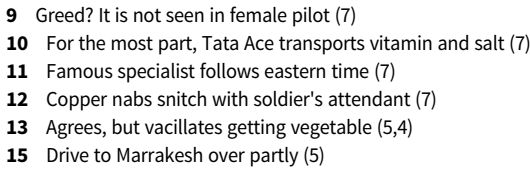
Govt. issues public consultation guidelines for highway projects after panel recommendations

Under the revised Request for Proposal (RFP) document for inviting bids from consultants to prepare DPRs, a mandatory provision for public consultation has been incorporated. For all brownfield projects, the Ministry in-



The panel had, in earlier meetings, flagged concerns that highways were often being constructed by sub-contractors not listed

BJP MP Ravi Shankar Prasad pointed out that ambulances required to be stationed at toll plazas were often absent, leading to delays in emergency response on highways, sources said.



- 16 Special wine (cold) altered muscle tone (7)
- 19 By deceit, cash given to sister's used to frame (7)
- 20 Gain a male animal (5)
- 21 Gladiator's role in South Africa's discussed centrally (9)
- 25 Explosive to primarily ruin someone like Epstein (7)
- 26 At the start, sudden noise baffled son entering a meeting (7)
- 28 Nurse corresponding with leading endocrinologist to join (7)
- 29 Son's team centre joins another team at beach (7)
- Down**
- 1 Touch actress badly to lose front tooth (6)
- 2 Goods arriving without name (6)
- 3 Limits excess centrally from rodents (4)
- 4 Spy's article creates rage (6)
- 5 Unruly trio can, at the border clandestinely get controlled submarine (8)
- 6 Downer from French media worker (10)
- 7 Careful about one in car, say at America (8)
- 8 It's unique; spy replaces man with lady in difficulty (8)
- 14 Cooking device for breads used by South American (10)
- 16 I ate an egg of a marine creature (3,5)
- 17 Enthusiasm offers one clarity somehow (8)
- 18 Client of Atticus, Tom, Eric protected (8)
- 22 Leading an animal to the front provides benefit (6)
- 23 Judge's important to evict gangster (6)
- 24 Say, diva spotted in a bus in Germany (6)
- 27 Collect sample of son and wife to get blood group (4)



Next, the words *jita sanga dosha* is a call to conquer attachment. Be committed to the mission, not addicted to one outcome, one client or one quarter's result. Third, the words *adhyatma-nitya* means stay anchored in purpose. Understand why you are doing this, beyond money or applause. Fourth, the words *vinivrita-kamah* ask you to be free from compulsive craving. Ambition is fuel. Craving is noise. Leaders with craving chase every shiny object and burn out teams. Fifth, *dvandvair vimuktah sukha-dukkha-samjnah*: asks you to rise above the pairs of opposites – success and failure, praise and criticism. If a win makes you arrogant and a loss makes you collapse, you are not leading. You are reacting. Do the job. However, do not let the job own you. That is the eternal abode Krishna points to: inner freedom in the middle of the fight.

Business

INBRIEF



Adani denies any deal linked to dismissal of case in the U.S.

Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani has denied under oath that there was any promise, agreement or deal behind the U.S. Department of Justice's move to dismiss a criminal indictment against him. The affidavit was filed in response to a July 8 order by the U.S. District Court for the Eastern District of New York asking Adani to state under oath whether he was aware of any promise, offer or agreement related to dismissal of the indictment. PTI

Indian Gas Exchange files IPO papers; parent to divest stake

Indian Gas Exchange Ltd. (IGX), the country's first online delivery-based trading platform for natural gas, has filed preliminary papers with markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) to launch an Initial Public Offering (IPO). The proposed public issue is entirely an Offer For Sale (OFS) of up to 1.67 crore equity shares by promoter Indian Energy Exchange Ltd (IEX), according to the Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) filed on Tuesday.

Sun Pharma gets nod for generic semaglutide injection

Sun Pharmaceutical Industries Ltd. on Wednesday said it has received approval from the South African Health Products Regulatory Authority (SAHPRA) to manufacture and market the generic version of semaglutide injection in South Africa for the treatment of adults with inadequately controlled type 2 diabetes mellitus as an adjunct to diet and exercise. In a regulatory filing, the company said it plans to launch the product in the market in the coming days. PTI

Global bids invited under PLI for 10 GWh ACC batteries

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Ministry of Heavy Industries has invited global bids to set up advanced battery manufacturing plants with a total capacity of 10 gigawatt-hours (GWh) in India under the government's Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme for Advanced Chemistry Cell (ACC) batteries.

These batteries will be used for grid-scale energy storage, helping store electricity generated from renewable sources such as solar and wind.

In 2021, the Centre approved an ₹18,100-crore PLI scheme to build 50 GWh of battery manufacturing capacity in India. Of

The objective is to cut dependence on imported ACCs by strengthening local manufacturing

this, 40 GWh has already been allocated to domestic manufacturers, with the remaining 10 GWh now open for bidding.

The objective of the scheme is to reduce India's dependence on imported ACCs by strengthening domestic manufacturing capabilities and incentivising large domestic and international players to establish a globally competitive ACC battery-manufacturing ecosystem in the country.

RBI issues data governance guidance framework for banks

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) issued the 'Guidance on Regulatory Expectations for Data Governance' for banks and other Regulated Entities (REs) prescribing a comprehensive framework to strengthen governance of data across the banking system.

The objective is to improve data quality, accountability, risk management and security while ensuring compliance with the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, and other applicable laws.

This has become important because with the in-



Reserve Bank of India REUTERS

creasing digitalisation of the financial sector and growing adoption of technology-driven business models, data has emerged as a critical asset for REs.

As the volume, variety and velocity of data conti-

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has cleared several projects, including ₹1.27 lakh crore for the second edition of India Semiconductor Mission and ₹62,500 crore for the mobile phone manufacturing scheme (MPMS) as part of efforts to localise manufacturing amid global geopolitical uncertainties.

The Cabinet also accorded approval to two major highway projects worth ₹25,400 crore to ease congestion in Varanasi and as many as nine new gas-based urea plants nationwide with a production capacity of 10 million tonnes.

Semicon Mission 2.0

The Cabinet has accorded approval for the ₹1.27 lakh crore for the second edition of India Semiconductor Mission through which the government expects to attract investments of around ₹4 lakh crore and lead to semiconductor production of ₹2 lakh crore during the scheme period.

The new edition of the semiconductor programme – which has provisions to incentivise even suppliers of raw material in the chip manufacturing industry, including minerals and gases – has come at an appropriate time when the

world is reeling under a memory chip shortage, and companies are working on plans to enhance production capacity. It also expects to attract investment from other chip segments to meet chip requirements for artificial intelligence devices.

Highlighting that “Semicon 2.0 will have six pillars. The first pillar will be the design of chips”; Information and Broadcasting (I&B) Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the programme will focus on design, development and production of indigenous chips. “We will be self-reliant in the production of indigenous chips by the end of this programme,” the minister said.

The government had allocated ₹76,000 crore for the first edition, under which it had approved 12 projects with cumulative investments of around ₹1.64 lakh crore.

The majority of the investment in the sector has come from technology firm Tata Electronics and its semiconductor arm.

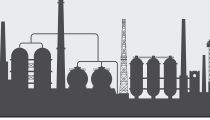
Mobile manufacturing

The Cabinet also approved an outlay of ₹62,500 crore for the MPMS, aimed at building Indian brands to achieve technological sovereignty and scale up local mobile production to capture the significant economic value, and create Indian patents in design and

Big ticket

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs chaired by PM Modi, cleared several projects across sectors

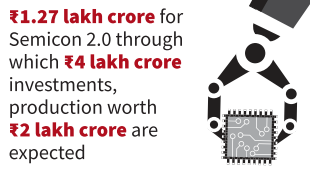
New National Investment Policy for Urea (NIPU-2026) to set up 8-9 new gas-based plants with a production capacity of 10 MT to make the country self-reliant



NHAI project under Hybrid Annuity Model to include a 43.218-km corridor linking NH-31 with Varanasi Ring Road for ₹10,998.32 crore; a 46.039-km corridor connecting NH-19 with the ring road at ₹14,447.64 crore

₹1.27 lakh crore for Semicon 2.0 through which ₹4 lakh crore investments, production worth ₹2 lakh crore are expected

₹62,500 crore for mobile phone manufacturing scheme, aimed at building Indian brands, scaling up local production



research and development.

“The scheme provides incentive support on eligible sales for manufacturing of mobile phones in India at differentiated rates ranging from 2.25% to 5%. Scheme also provides additional incentive of up to 1.5% linked to domestic sourcing of key components/sub-assemblies. For building Indian brands, an additional incentive at 3% on eligible sales for design and R&D of the product,” an official release said.

During the scheme tenure, the cumulative mobile phone production in the country is expected to reach about ₹39 lakh crore with significant increase in exports of mobile phones. The scheme is also expected to generate around 60,000 direct jobs thereby

contributing to economic growth, the release added.

Highways

The highway projects, to be implemented by the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) under the Hybrid Annuity Model (HAM), include a 43.218 kilometre (km)corridor linking NH-31 with the Varanasi Ring Road along Varuna River at a total capital cost of ₹10,998.32 crore and a 46.039 km corridor connecting NH-19 with the ring road along the Ganga River at a cost of ₹14,447.64 crore. The NH-19 project will feature a six-lane elevated carriageway, a cable-stayed bridge, an extra-dosed foot over bridge-cum-major bridge, loops, ramps, link roads and service roads. The NH-31 corridor will comprise a pre-

India-U.K. FTA a boost for farmers and small,medium firms, says PM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI

PM Narendra Modi said the India-U.K. Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), taking effect Wednesday, will boost Indian farmers' incomes, entrepreneurs and micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs).

“The CETA will give fresh momentum to farmers, entrepreneurs and MSMEs,” he posted on X.

“Several vibrant sectors will gain stronger access to U.K. market. It will deepen cooperation in technology, professional services and innovation, while supporting greater mobility for skilled Indian talent.”

He said the Double Contribution Convention will



Narendra Modi

provide “invaluable support to Indian professionals” working temporarily in the U.K. and boost ‘our firms’ competitiveness.’

“All the U.K. cities are looking at India with great excitement,” Harjinder Kang, the U.K.'s Trade Commissioner for South Asia and British Deputy High Commissioner for Western India and one of

the lead negotiators of the trade pact, said, adding the bilateral trade between the two countries stood at £45 billion in 2024 and rose to £48 billion in 2026 even in the absence of a deal.

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said, “It [the deal] opens new frontiers for IT, professional, financial, education and business services sectors while expanding mobility for Indian talent.”

Meanwhile, Maharashtra CM symbolically flagged off the first consignment of goods from India to the U.K. under CETA.

Rajeev Singh, DG, Indian Chamber of Commerce said, “Securing duty-free access for 99% of exports is no small achievement. Textiles

stand out in particular. Our exporters in Tiruppur and Surat have long operated at a duty disadvantage against Bangladesh and Cambodia in the U.K. and that gap now closes, giving an entire manufacturing ecosystem room to grow.”

Services also to gain

Chandrajit Banerjee, DG, Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), said, “Enhanced market access across IT, financial, professional, education and healthcare services with improved mobility provisions and Double Contribution Convention, will boost global competitiveness of Indian firms and professionals in the U.K.”

(With inputs from Vinaya Deshpande)

Indian government set to invest ₹200 cr. in Ather Energy

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Government of India will invest ₹200 crore in Ather Energy through India-Japan Fund (IJF), a joint investment vehicle backed by the Government of India and the Japan Bank for International Cooperation.

Founders Tarun Mehta and Swapnil Jain are also participating in the fundraising round, investing ₹20 crore each, along with other existing promoters and IJF. Hero MotoCorp (HMC) is set to invest ₹960 crore as part of the fundraise, according to Ather Energy's regulatory filing.

All promoter investments in the round are being made at a premium of



Ather Energy showroom

₹85 to the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI)-mandated floor price. The firm would issue 79.36 lakh warrants at ₹1,260/warrant to HMC and promoters and 16.26 lakh equity shares at ₹1,230 per share to IJF.

The board had okayed preferential allotment of about ₹1,000 crore.

SEBI bans board from new stock, related instruments

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) has classified investments allowed for board members, including chairperson into permitted and non-permitted investments in its now stricter Code of Conduct Rules for Board Members 2026.

The entirely new code was released on July 15 after the capital market watchdog said the board made the announcement of the release after the first quarter meet on June 19.

According to the new code, equity or converti-

ble-to equity instruments and derivatives fall under non-permitted investments. Investment via a regulated pooled investment vehicle such as a SIP or SIF among others and buying units of INVIT and REITs are permitted investments, the regulator said.

Moreover, Whole Time Members will now come under insider trading rules and be considered a person with price sensitive information. The 2008 code stopped with mandating disclosure for members' and families' ownership/other investments in listed, to-be-listed and regulated intermediaries of SEBI.

TELANGANA MEDICAL SERVICES & INFRASTRUCTURE DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION
3rd Floor, DM & HS Campus, Sultan Bazar,Koti, Hyderabad - 505 Ph. No.040-40332988; email: telcsmidc@gmail.com
Tender Notice No.4/TGMSIDC/Civil/2026-27, Dated: 13.07.2026.
Tenders are invited through e-procurement platform for the following works: (1) Establishment of 50 bedded Integrated AYUSH Hospital at Karimnagar; (2) Construction of New Building (OP Block) at Area Hospital Golconda, Hyderabad; (3) Establishment of (416) Dialysis beds in the (79) Government Hospitals in Telangana State under PPP mode. The other details can be seen at our website <http://www.tgmsidc.telangana.gov.in> and <https://tender.telangana.gov.in>.
Sd/- (dt:13.07.2026)
DIPR R.O.No.6137-PP/CL/ADVT/2026-27 Dt. 15.07.2026 MANAGING DIRECTOR

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Note: PLL reserves the right not to issue the tender document and/or accept or reject any or all the bids at any stage of the process and/or modify the process without assigning any reasons on its sole discretion. No separate notification w.r.t. this tender shall be issued in press. Interested parties to regularly visit aforesaid PLL website for any updates.
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Tel: No. -0484-2757702 / 1
Email : cnp_kochi@petronetlmg.in; shriranga@petronetlmg.in

BLUNT ASSESSMENT

We faced one of the best, but they faced the best: de la Fuente



AFP

Luis de la Fuente hailed his players, saying Spain proved it is “the best team in the world”. “We started almost four years ago with an idea, and we’ve been faithful to that idea, and it’s brought us here. Today we faced one of the best teams in the world, but in front of them they had the best team in the world. That is different”.

HONEST

We made technical mistakes and didn’t find solutions: Deschamps



AFP

Spain defended very well. They left us very little space. Because we made technical mistakes, it became difficult to create problems for them. We were below our usual level and made more technical errors than in previous matches. We were a step short physically and did not find solutions — France coach Didier Deschamps.

TACTICALLY OUTPLAYED

Mbappe calls France ‘sloppy’ after the semifinal reverse to Spain



AP

Kylian Mbappe said France was too “sloppy” to keep Spain from controlling the game. “We were three against two in midfield and against Spain, that’s hard. Fabian and Rodri had plenty of time to play. We should’ve done man-to-man press and forced them to run with us. We didn’t play the game we wanted, technically, tactically”.

SURREAL

Spain’s Porro says ‘dream come true’ to reach World Cup final



AP

Pedro Porro, who scored Spain's second goal in the 2-0 win over France, said reaching the World Cup final was “a dream come true”. “I am very happy with the team’s attitude from start to finish. We played a great match; we did everything we had to do today to reach the final. It’s a dream come true”.

Spain’s masterclass dismantles France’s star-power

Oyarzabal strokes home the opener from the spot after Digne trips up Yamal; Porro adds gloss to the scoreline; *Les Bleus’* fearsome attack is rendered toothless by the disciplined *La Roja*

FIFA WORLD CUP

Agence France-Presse
DALLAS

Spain snuffed out France’s dream of a third World Cup triumph on Tuesday, taming its galaxy of forwards to win 2-0 and progress to a final against England or Argentina.

Didier Deschamps’ men – hot favourites after a string of breathtaking displays – met their match against the slick European champion in the semifinals.

Emphatic penalty

Mikel Oyarzabal opened the scoring for the 2010 winner with an emphatic penalty in the first half and Pedro Porro doubled the lead in the second.

Shell-shocked France could not find a way back into the match despite its wealth of attacking riches.

The game caught fire midway through the first half when Salvadoran referee Ivan Barton pointed to the spot after a reckless challenge by France left-back Lucas Digne on Spain winger Lamine Yamal.

Oyarzabal hammered the ball past goalkeeper Mike Maignan for his fifth goal of this edition.

Saliba leaves the pitch

Minutes later France suffered another blow when centre-back William Saliba had to leave the pitch after a recurrence of his lower back injury, replaced by Crystal Palace defender Maxence Lacroix.

Agonisingly close

Spain went agonisingly close to extending its lead after some dazzling one-touch football but Dayot Upamecano’s challenge denied Fabian Ruiz.

Deschamps threw on Desire Doue for Bradley



Body blow: Porro caps off an intricate team move to slot in Spain’s second. REUTERS

Stat attack

O Mbappe failed to have a single shot on target for the first time since the 2022 quarterfinal against England

Since joining Real Madrid, Mbappe has lost every knockout match for club or country against Yamal

France suffered its biggest defeat in a knockout game since the 1986 semifinals (0-2 vs. West Germany)

Spain earned the distinction of being the first to register six clean sheet victories in a campaign

Oyarzabal became the third Spaniard to net five or more goals in an edition (Villa in 2010 and Butragueno in 1986)



Simon recorded the most clean sheets by a goalkeeper in a single tournament

Spain defeated France for the eighth time in its last 11 matches across all competitions

With his 30th international strike, Oyarzabal moved to sixth in Spain’s goalscoring list

Rodri completed 655 passes, the most in a single edition

Spain’s 37-game unbeaten streak in all competitions (28 wins, 9 draws) pulled it level with Italy (2018-21) for the longest one by a European nation

COMPILED BY ANIRUDH VELAMURI

THE RESULT

Final: France 0 lost to Spain 2 (Oyarzabal 22-pen, Porro 58).

edge of the box and collected the return ball before coolly slotting past Maignan. Deschamps threw on

Theo Hernandez and Rayan Cherki after the second hydration break in a desperate bid to get back into the match.

But France could not find a way back into the game against a solid opponent who refused to yield.

How the Spanish midfield choked France

Ayon Sengupta

France had arrived in Dallas carrying the tournament’s most feared attack. Kylian Mbappe, Ousmane Dembele and Michael Olise had combined for 13 goals and 10 assists in six matches as opponents struggled to contain them. By the end of the semifinal, Spain had made that frightening front three look almost anonymous.

The scoreline read 2-0, but the performance was even more emphatic.

Spain reached its first World Cup final since lifting the trophy in Johannesburg 16 years ago by producing perhaps the tournament’s most complete display, suffocating Didier Deschamps’ side through relentless pressing, immaculate possession and defensive organisation.

France managed only three shots on target and rarely looked capable of disturbing a Spanish side that controlled both the ball and the rhythm of the evening.

Rodri and Fabian Ruiz controlled the midfield while Pau Cubarsi and Aymeric Laporte stepped forward to nullify the threat of Mbappe, who failed to register a single shot on target for the first time in his last nine World Cup appearances.

Luis de la Fuente’s side has reached the final having conceded just one goal in seven matches.

It has now gone 37 matches unbeaten in all competitions and stands one win away from becoming only the third reigning European champion to follow it up with the World Cup.

Spain reduced *Les Bleus* to just 0.30 expected goals



Bossing the turf: Spain’s relentless pressing, immaculate possession and defensive organisation suffocated France. REUTERS



– France’s lowest attacking output at a World Cup in six decades. France attempted only 10 shots, with just one coming from inside 13 metres of the Spanish goal.

Spain’s defending begins long before opponents reach its centre-backs. Ro-

dri and Ruiz monopolise possession, the press forces hurried decisions, passing lanes disappear and attacks are extinguished before they gather momentum.

That collective understanding has become Spain’s greatest strength.

Lamine Yamal dazzles, Rodri dictates, Cubarsi defends with the assurance of a veteran, while Mikel Oyarzabal continues his habit of deciding the biggest matches.

Pedro Porro, whose first responsibility is usually to stop elite forwards, scored the second goal that put this contest to bed. The stars change from game to game because the system remains.

Spain has the most forced turnovers (303) in the tournament, has tried

the most passes (4592) with a 91 percent success rate and also had the most defensive line breaks attempted (175) with a 65 percent success rate, while topping the charts in almost all movement metrics.

For years, Spain was admired for its possession but questioned for lacking the cutting edge.

This generation has found the balance. It monopolises the ball without becoming sterile, attacks without losing structure and defends without retreating.

Only one team has found a way past Unai Simon in seven World Cup matches.

With one game remaining, that may be the statistic that defines Spain’s tournament.

Men in Blue look to build on the positives

INDIA IN ENGLAND

N. Sudarshan
CARDIFF

Banking on a new set of actors to switch up performances when ratings dip is common practice in the showbiz industry.

For Indian cricket, a new set of entertainers arrived in time and helped deliver a moderate box-office hit in the form of a six-wicket victory in the first ODI versus England in Birmingham on Tuesday.

First success

It was the away side’s first success after six T20 defeats during the ongoing sojourn of the United Kingdom.

In the second match of

the series at Sophia Gardens here on Thursday, there will be another opportunity to build on the positives.

Captain Shubman Gill scored a typically classy 80 before having to retire hurt owing to cramps.

Gill expected to play

The 26-year-old is expected to be fit for the encounter here, despite the short turnaround time.

Jasprit Bumrah, in his first ODI in nearly three years, bowled nine miserly overs for 31 runs.

The 32-year-old troubled Ben Duckett with his swing early on, and had skipper Harry Brook caught at slip with a delivery that bounced a tad more and left the batter in two minds.

But it was not a happy return for the star duo of Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli.

Rohit looked scrappy in his 21-ball stay for 11 runs while Kohli was out leg-before for five after playing across the line to Jofra Archer.

Rohit, 39, has not been at his aggressive best for a while. Since the Champions Trophy triumph in March 2025, he has batted 13 times in ODIs, and has scored one century, four half-centuries, and a 48.

These are not bad numbers per se, but as Novak Djokovic said at Wimbledon, greats are “blessed and cursed to be used to the highest degree in terms of results and achievements.” For Kohli, runs haven’t

been an issue, for he had a productive IPL with Royal Challengers Bengaluru. But he would like to get back into his scoring rhythm quickly after having missed the home series against Afghanistan with a hamstring injury.

England, on the other hand, will want its present personnel to step up, for the loss in Edgbaston was its 20th in the 30 ODIs since the 2023 World Cup.

Of particular concern will be the collapse it suffered from 61 for no loss to 107 for six, with Brook, Jos Buttler and Sam Curran falling for a collective score of six.

Lack of game awareness

There was also a severe lack of game awareness from the tail when the last

three wickets fell for just eight runs. With Joe Root at the other end, all that Archer, Adil Rashid and Josh Tongue had to do was turn the strike over.

But Archer perished trying to hammer Axar Patel while Rashid paid the price for stepping out of the crease as England folded with 13 deliveries still remaining.

Top-order’s duty

Brook later said that it was the top-order that needed to shoulder more responsibility rather than the bowlers being asked to be better at their secondary skill. But in the cut-throat universe of international cricket, every run counts.

Match starts at 5.30 p.m. IST.



Putting their hand up: Axar and Washington were at the forefront of India’s win in Birmingham. AP & REUTERS



 TAMILNADU CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' FEDERATION LIMITED, ICE CREAM PLANT, MADURAI - 625 020							
Ref.No: 384/MICP/Admn/2025			TENDER NOTICE			Dt:08.07.2026	
Tenders are invited from the contractors through online for 1) Providing of Rs. unskilled manpower for Housekeeping works at Ice Cream Plant, Madurai-625 020 for 24 months for the years 2026-2028 and 2) Providing 12 Nos. of ITI/Diploma qualified manpower for 3 shifts at Ice Cream Plant, Madurai-625 020 for 24 months for the year 2026-2028.							
Sl. No.	Description	No of workers required	Approximate estimated value (Rs. in lakh)	Permitted Date & Time for tender document download at free of cost	Pre Bid meeting	Last date for Submission of Tenders Documents	Opening of Technical bid
1	For Providing of 12 Nos. of unskilled manpower for Housekeeping works at Ice Cream Plant, Madurai-625 020 for 24 months for the year 2026-2028.	8 Nos.	Rs. 54.00 Lakh	17/07/2026 to 31/07/2026 upto 4.00 pm	23.07.2026 at 11.00 am	31/07/2026 at 4.00 pm	03.08.2026 at 11.00 am
2	Providing 12 Nos. of ITI/Diploma qualified manpower for 3 shifts at Ice Cream Plant, Madurai-625 020 for 24 months for the year 2026-2028. Ref.No:385/MICP/Admn/2025	12 Nos.	Rs. 91.00 Lakh	17/07/2026 to 31/07/2026 upto 4.00 pm	23.07.2026 at 11.30 am	31/07/2026 at 4.00 pm	03.08.2026 at 11.30 am
The Tender documents can be submitted as e-tendering through the e-procurement website " https://tenders.gov.in ". The bidders can check the website https://avin.tn.gov.in for reference for item-wise specifications, EMD amount payable etc. For further details see the tender documents.							
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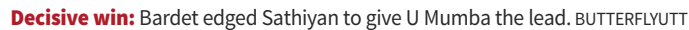
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Anusha pulls off a crucial victory in the final singles match to help the defending champion best Dabang Delhi 8-7

K. Keerthivasan
PANAJI

The odds were firmly stacked against Dabang Delhi's Maria Xiao when she walked out to face U Mumba TT's Anusha Kuttumale in the fifth and deciding match of the Ultimate Table Tennis Season 7 at the Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Indoor Stadium on Wednesday.

Moments earlier, Mumbai's Lilian Bardet had edged past G. Sathiyani 2-1 in a fiercely contested singles match to hand the defending champion a 7-5 lead. With just one game needed from the final match to secure the tie, the advantage lay squarely on

Anusha. Though Anusha lost the first two games, she came up with an excellent counter-attacking effort in the third to win the game that mattered to give U Mumba its first win of the season 8-7.

Mumba's Manush Shah has not been at his best in this edition. If there has been one glaring weakness in his game, it has been a lack of consistency.

Against Youssef Abdelaiz in the opening match, Manush seldom displayed the patience or discipline needed to build points. Particularly in the opening game, he appeared eager to end rallies too quickly, going for ambitious winners before constructing the point.

The resulting unforced errors prevented him from

finding any rhythm and he lost 1-2. Mumba's Anna Hursey extended her unbeaten run in the singles, with a hard-fought 2-1 victory over Sutirtha Mukherjee, to level the tie at 3-3.

It was a huge upset in the third match as Manush found his attacking touch and Anna kept within herself as the mixed doubles pair ousted Sathiyani and Maria Xiao to swing the momentum in Mumba's favour at 5-4.

The results: U Mumba TT bt Delhi Dabang 8-7 (Manush Shah lost to Youssif Abdelaziz 11-9, 11-4, 6-11; Anna Hursey bt Sutirtha Mukherjee 9-11, 11-7, 11-6; Manush & Anna bt Sathiyani & Maria Xiao 11-4, 8-11, 11-8; Lilian Bardet bt Sathiyani 11-10, 8-11, 11-8; Anusha Kutumbale lost to Maria Xiao 10-11, 9-11, 11-10).

K. Keerthivasan
PANAJI

The Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT) Season 7 has once again lived up to its reputation of giving youngsters the platform to showcase their potential and they have grabbed the opportunity with both hands.

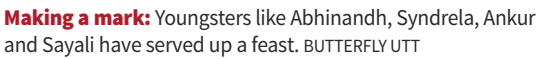
At the Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Indoor Stadium here, it has been these young paddlers who have injected the league with energy, fearlessness and fresh ambition. Time and again, they have delivered much-needed breakthroughs for their franchises, swung the momentum with fearless performances, thrown the rankings out of the window, and in the process, propelled their teams ahead in the race for crucial points.

They have served up memorable contests for the modest gathering at the stadium and the OTT audience producing performances rich in skill, composure and daring that fans are likely to cherish for a long time.

It was P.B. Abhinandh of Dempo Goa Challengers who opened the floodgates for Gen Z. The 18-year-old matched 25-year-old Frenchman Lilian Bardet in both attack and defence by displaying maturity that belied his age.

It was refreshing to see him with such freedom, composure and nonchalance, and his victory unleashed a wave that continued through to 20-year-old Sayali Wani of UP Prometheus defeating Ahmedabad APL Pipers' Manika Batra on Tuesday.

The paddler who has



borne the brunt of the 'youth aggression' has been Manika, a three-time Olympian and multiple Commonwealth Games medalist. The 31-year-old has lost all her singles matches so far. While her defeat to Anna Hurney could perhaps be dismissed as an off day against an accomplished international, her losses to 16-year-old Syndrela Das and 20-year-old Sayali cannot be viewed in the same light.

The manner in which Syndrela dismantled Manika was a lesson in fearless, attacking table tennis. The teenager had an answer to every variation Manika's racket could conjure up. Syndrela's backhand down-the-line and cross-court winners repeatedly left the veteran stranded.

Equally impressive was HVR Kolkata ThunderBlades' Ankur Bhattacharjee's victory over 33-year-old G. Sathiyan. A powerhouse of talent, the 19-year-old produced a masterclass in aggressive play, refusing to yield an inch, as he relentlessly attacked and broke through Sathiyan's famed defence. His celebration of standing atop the table after the victory, however, was not in the spirit of the game.

Taneesha Kotecha's win over Diya Chitale, Payas Jain's victory against Manush Shah, and the high-quality contests featuring Abhinandh against Ankur and Payas illustrated how far the country's young paddlers have progressed. Their shot-making, tactical awareness and ability to absorb pressure reflected a generation that is no longer content merely to compete with established names.

At the same time, there remains considerable room for improvement. Syndrela, for instance, struggled against the anti-spin rubber used by Kolkata's Ayhika Mukherjee, highlighting the need to adapt better to different styles and equipment.

This season has demonstrated that Indian table tennis has a vibrant pipeline of talent and that a new generation is keen to take the sport to greater heights.



C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

The heat is on in Chennai. It is also time to brace up for some heated battles on the chessboard as the stage is set for the first move in the fourth edition of the Quantbox Chennai Grand Masters chess tournament at Hotel Westin Velachery on Thursday.

The reigning World champion D. Gukesh, whose diminishing returns since his ascension to the throne have sparked a lot of chatter, will be eyeing a return to form in the lead-up to the championship match against Javokhir Sindarov.

He will have his task cut out in a eight-man field that features Frenchman Alireza Firouzja, Sindarov's Uzbek compatriot Nodirbek Abdusattorov, American Hans Niemann and fellow Indians Arjun Erigaisi and Nihal Sarin.

Coming off modest returns in Norway Chess and the Grand Chess Tour event in Croatia, Gukesh would be hoping for home comfort.

Former World Rapid champion Abdusattorov, the highest rated player in the fray, will start favourite, entering the event on the back of a runner-finish in GCT-Croatia.

Firouzja, the champion in Croatia, will be the player to beat here. Erigaisi, who didn't have a great outing in the tournament last year and Nihal, who is also returning to the event, would look to make their best moves.

M. Praneish, the victor in the Challenger section in 2024 and Russia's Dmitry Andreikin won't just want to make up the numbers and put up a good show against some of the best.

It's over to Gukesh and the rest to sizzle on the chessboard.

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Everyone wants to win gold at the Asian extravaganza

Sarvesh Kushare adopts well-prepared training methods to better Tejaswin's eight-year-old National record; coach Jithin feels the tweaks made in the run-up make the difference



BISWARANJAN ROUT & RITU RAJ KONWAR

Y.B. Sarangi

On June 27 evening, immediately after Sarvesh Kushare ended his four-year quest to better Tejaswin Shankar's eight-year-old high jump National record of 2.28m at the National inter-state athletics meet at Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar by clearing 2.31m, Tejaswin took to his 'X' handle to write: "Another mental barrier broken!! 2.30+ was probably the last of the sticky records. 2.34-35 is just a matter of time."

Worlds and Olympics gold medallist javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra endorsed Tejaswin's statement, and Sarvesh's achievement of becoming the first Indian to go past 2.30m, by reposting it.

With very few world-class marks to their name, Indian athletes' hunger for success is understandable. Perhaps that appetite kept 30-year-old Sarvesh patient in the hunt to surpass the 2.30m barrier. He had missed it by a whisker when he recorded 2.28m at the Federation meet in Ranchi a month ago, before seeing his perseverance rewarded.

No excuse

"At 2.28m, my ankle slipped a little in Ranchi. I was in good condition. I still had a light injury. But I had to do it today. There was no excuse. The weather was good. The ground was also good. Overall, there was a lot of motivation. I also held the Asian Games qualifying mark for the first time. I'm improving – what more can I ask for!" said Sarvesh.

"My body felt good. My coach had said it would happen this time. I was determined. 2.30m was not happening despite my long-time effort to get it. So, I

thought today I would do 2.31m. It was a lot of fun doing that," said Sarvesh, as he displayed different antics as the bar went up and up and he kept sailing over it effortlessly.

"It was very difficult to go above 2.30m. If Tejaswin had not done 2.28m in 2018, I would not have come this far. I was also progressing slowly. Today, by the grace of God, everything went well. I have tried this during training, but I had not done it so well prior to today. Since our preparation was top-class, anything was possible."

Now, 2.31m has placed Sarvesh as the joint fourth season leader in the world, along with British jumper Kimani Jack, and first in Asia, ahead of tied-fifth spot holders Japan's Naoto Hasegawa and Tomohiro Shinno and Korea's Sanghyeok Woo, who have all cleared 2.30m.

"Everyone wants to win a gold medal at the Asian Games. I will also try to win one," said Sarvesh.

Pressure under control

Sarvesh's coach Jithin Thomas, a former Asian silver medallist with a personal best of 2.22m, shared his thoughts about the feat. "This time, the pressure was under control. I told him to stay focused and control the pressure. This time, the work was about that. I knew if we controlled the pressure, then the jump would happen."

For Sarvesh, who competed in the Paris Olympics and was a finalist at the Tokyo World Championships last year, the right pace of his run-up did the trick. Apart from the requisite exercises, visualisation is a main activity in Sarvesh's training.

"The difference was the run-up. Earlier, he used to pick up speed from the

beginning and move uncontrollably. He was trying to speed up too early. Now, in the beginning, the speed was under control. Then gradually, it went up. He was trained that way. He needs to work on it. I told him, 'Stay focused and you will clear it smoothly.'

"I told him that no one has done 2.30m in India. If you do 2.30m, your name will be up there as long as high jump is there in India."

Patience pays

"In high jump, there is a mark for everyone. Then it becomes stagnant. Some people pursue it for two-three years and leave it. If you have patience, then you will be able to improve it. Because Sarvesh had the patience, he could do it. There was this belief that he would do it, so now there is relief. It's the greatest day of my life. "Because he had done (well earlier), he was after it. We were focused. We were careful that he should not pick up any injuries. There were small injuries. Still, we were focused. We kept talking about it. The mark kept improving and we were able to do it."

With a smile, Sarvesh, who hails from a village near Nashik in Maharashtra, quipped, "He (Jithin) spoke very little to me this week. I don't know what he was thinking."

Sarvesh acknowledges that the support extended by his coach, his family, his employer the Indian Army, his sponsor OGO, and the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) played a key role in his journey. "I am confident. If the training goes well and there are no injuries, then confidence will increase. If everyone's support is there, then we can go ahead. Especially my coach, who has not taken any leave for seven months, and my

family members are very supportive. That's why I am able to do it. Otherwise, I would have been disturbed."

Sarvesh is happy to note that Indian jumpers, including women's National record holder Pooja Singh – who, like Sarvesh, trains at the Anju Bobby George Academy in Bengaluru – are doing well. "Yes, it did impact me mentally that Pooja broke the National mark. She set a record of 1.93m. We were thinking that we would do well. She made a National record before me. I did it after her. Dev Meena is also doing well in pole vault. He is also breaking National records. This is a good year for jumpers." Needless to say, long jumpers Ancy Sojan, who broke Anju's 22-year-old National record, and M. Sreesankar and Shahnavaz Khan, who achieved his season best, are also among the Indians who have achieved world-class marks this season.

Encouraging sign

Even in men's high jump, the presence of some good athletes, including Tejaswin, Adarsh Ram, and Basant, is an encouraging sign. "A pool of jumpers should be there – only then can there be improvement. Otherwise, Sarvesh will be alone. Whoever achieves something first, his name remains up there," said Jithin.

After breaching the 2.30m peak in June, Sarvesh became the first Indian high jumper to earn a podium, by finishing third with a mark of 2.26m, on his Diamond League debut in Monaco on July 10. Now, Sarvesh and his coach Jithin are bubbling with confidence while eyeing higher marks and glorious medals in the upcoming Commonwealth Games and Asian Games. "I hope Sarvesh maintains his focus and patience. He will go far," said Jithin.

THE GIST

▼

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Sarvesh and his coach Jithin are bubbling with confidence while eyeing higher marks and glorious medals in the upcoming Commonwealth Games and Asian Games

A new era of Indian ecology looks to its horizons, and to the ground

Ankita Rathore
SONEPAT

CM
YK

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Cost of energy relief package planned by Germany for 2027

13.3 € billion. The German government plans an energy cost relief package for businesses and consumers worth €13.3 billion (\$15.2 billion) in 2027, to be drawn from the Climate and Transformation Fund, the Finance Ministry said on Wednesday. REUTERS

Number of Ebola cases in Democratic Republic of the Congo

2,000 More than 2,000 Ebola cases, including 754 deaths, have been recorded in the DR Congo, where the World Health Organization warns the outbreak may be two to four times larger than official figures suggest. AFP

Persons affected due to flood situation in Arunachal Pradesh

1 lakh. The flood situation in Arunachal Pradesh worsened on Wednesday, with 26 of the State's 28 districts affected and the number of people hit by the deluge crossing one lakh, an official bulletin said. The floods and landslides have so far claimed seven lives and injured 29 people across the State. PTI

Value of goods exported on India-U.K. trade pact's first day

140 \$ million. India has exported goods worth \$140 million to the United Kingdom at zero duty under the comprehensive economic and trade agreement (CETA), which became operational on Wednesday, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said. PTI

Dementia risk that could be prevented or delayed

45 in per cent. Up to 45% of dementia risk could be prevented or delayed, the World Health Organization said on Wednesday, citing modifiable risk factors such as tobacco and air pollution. It is the seventh leading cause of death. AFP

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The problem with China's 4.3% growth

It's the slowest growth since 2022, when China was still in the grips of the pandemic, and below the government's already-lowered annual target of 4.5-5%; the country is facing multiple challenges of a real estate slowdown, sluggish consumption, and serious challenges in the job market

WORLD INSIGHT

Ananth Krishnan

China's economy grew 4.3% in the second quarter of 2026, according to data released on Wednesday by China's National Bureau of Statistics (NBS). With growth falling to the lowest in more than three years and below the government's already lowered annual target of 4.5-5%, attention has turned to how the Chinese government is likely to deal with multiple challenges of a real estate slowdown, sluggish consumption, and serious challenges in the job market.

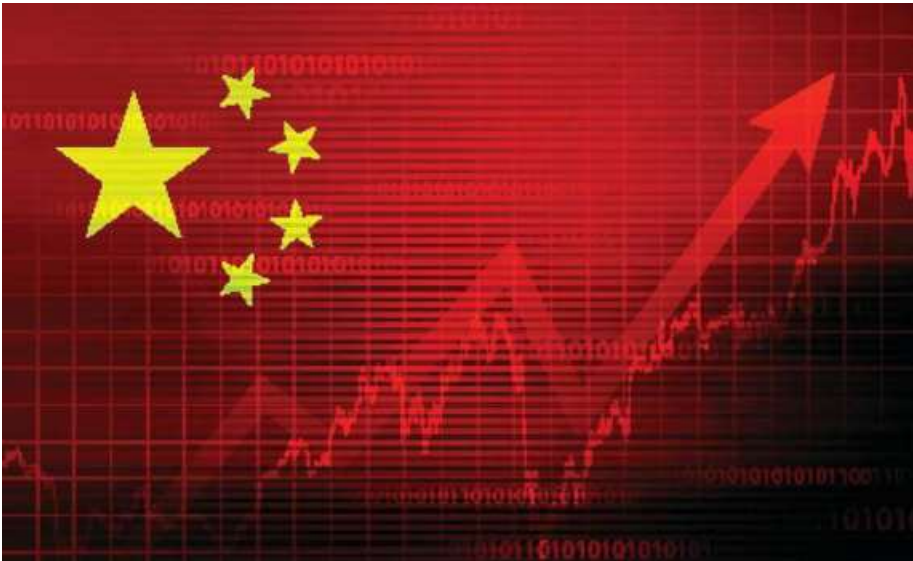
A meeting of the ruling Communist Party's Politburo slated for July-end is likely to offer some clues. China's surging exports have emerged as a bright spot for Beijing, while raising questions for India and other trade partners that are grappling with ever-widening trade imbalances.

What does the latest data show?

China's GDP expanded by 4.3% in the second quarter, down from 5% in the first quarter. This marked the slowest growth since 2022, when China was still in the grips of the pandemic. Significantly, growth fell below the annual target. In March 2026, China's National People's Congress (NPC), or Parliament, announced a 4.5-5% target for the year, which was the lowest since 1991.

Other economic indicators released on Wednesday showed a 5.7% drop in fixed-asset investment and sluggish retail sales — an important marker of consumption, which the government hopes will drive future growth for a historically investment-reliant economy.

In May, retail sales fell 0.6% from last year, another low since the pandemic. June showed a slight recovery to a 1.1% increase in retail sales of goods. Usual caveats apply about China's economic data, which China's former Premier Li Keqiang himself reportedly once advised were for "reference only" (and that other indicators, such as freight and power consumption, were arguably more revelatory about the state of the



China's GDP expanded by 4.3% in the second quarter. The numbers reveal how the government wants to portray the state of the economy and may signal potential policy changes. GETTY IMAGES

economy). At the same time, it is important to note that economists still closely study China's official data, as numbers reveal how the government wants to portray the state of the economy and may signal potential policy changes. Most economists have noted improvements in the reliability of statistics, with numbers becoming harder to fudge coinciding with the global integration of China's economy and more transparency into the performance of Chinese companies, many of which are publicly listed.

What is driving down growth?

If real estate is about "location, location, location", China's slowdown story is in many ways about "real estate, real estate and real estate". In the first half of the year, property investment fell 18%, a remarkable statistic for an economy once driven by real estate growth. This isn't only about the property sector. The spillover effects are hard to overstate.

An entire swathe of the economy is in a slump, from construction to every related industry that has for decades relied on a booming property sector, from lighting to furniture. Then there is the psychological impact in a country where most people's savings are locked into real estate given

the low returns from regulated interest rates that make bank deposits unappealing. Investing abroad is also not an option given the tight capital controls, although the stock market has emerged as an alternative avenue despite its volatility.

This has further dampened the willingness of Chinese consumers to spend, along with other persisting anxieties such as rising healthcare and education costs. Still, there are bright spots for the Chinese economy such as the rapid growth in China's high-tech industries and the continuing expansion of Chinese exports, from electric vehicles to most recently, an extraordinary surge in the exports of air-conditioners to Europe amid a summer heat wave. Trade still remains robust for China, growing 17% in the first half of the year. Exports grew for 11 consecutive quarters to \$2.1 trillion in the first six months of the year.

How is the government likely to respond?

All eyes are on an upcoming meeting of the Politburo, the top policy-making body of the Communist Party of China, set for late July. Mao Shengyong, deputy director of the NBS, said on Wednesday the government was likely to "introduce targeted, more proactive and effective

policies in response to changing circumstances", without specifying.

Boosting domestic consumption and minimising job losses are likely to top its concerns, especially with many graduates currently entering the workforce. Urban unemployment remained flat at 5% in June. Mr. Mao said "efforts will be stepped up to secure the steady development of employment", with a target to create 12 million new urban jobs in 2026, despite the concerns about hiring impacted by AI. Earlier this week, China announced a first of its kind five-year plan for consumption, with a 2030 retail sales target of 60 trillion yuan (\$8.86 trillion), a 20% rise from 2025.

Addressing the property sector — the elephant in the room — is one major challenge. The government has walked a tightrope of avoiding what it calls "systemic risks" while trying to protect buyers (as it needs to, if consumption is to revive) while not bailing out many developers. This is part of an ongoing effort to reform the sector and curb speculation, after Chinese President Xi Jinping's declaration in 2016 that "houses were for living in and not speculation".

The broader problem for Beijing is that it's not only property developers but local governments also have been hard hit by the slump, with real estate sales a major contributor of revenues. Many tier-two and tier-three cities have seen a major cash crunch, impacting spending on infrastructure and social services. The extent of the crunch remains unclear with some taking to fudging data to mask the state of their finances, as the Communist Party's own anti-corruption watchdog warned recently. It cited the example of one plot of land being sold "18 times" in the southern city of Nanning "without ever changing hands", reported the *South China Morning Post*, with the fudge allowing "the city government to artificially shore up its fiscal revenue by 2.83 billion yuan (US\$416 million) in 2024".

"Captivated by quick gains," it warned, "some authorities engaged in accounting gimmicks to reflect substantial rises in fiscal revenue, masking actual budget strains."

THE GIST

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Digitisation and efficiency in criminal justice system

The shift in approach to justice has contributed to making the criminal justice system more citizen-oriented

LETTER AND SPIRIT

C.B.P. Srivastava

Recently, the Centre has announced that India aims for full digital rollout of its criminal justice system from July 1, 2027 after which the procedures related to investigations and trials under the new criminal laws will be recorded digitally through the Interoperable Criminal Justice System. The efficiency of any criminal justice system largely depends on the procedural efficiency beginning from the registration of the first information report (FIR) to investigation, filing of chargesheet outlining specific charges levelled against the accused and presenting the evidence and witness testimonies gathered to substantiate them, trial and finally the disposal. In the

digital system the data is stored on the government's cloud platform, MeghRaj.

Understanding criminal justice system

The criminal justice system comprises the police, courts, prisons, forensics, and prosecution services, and aims at ensuring that individuals who suffer injury or loss at the hand of others can present their cases and seek justice.

Justice cannot be delivered unless the rights of the accused and the interests of the victim and the society are balanced. This has been the fundamental principle of the criminal justice system, particularly in common law countries that follow the adversarial system. These countries base their legal systems primarily on judicial precedents and uncodified case law rather than strict statutory codes. This principle also gives the accused a fair chance to present his case in accordance with the tenets of natural justice, that is,

the rule of fair hearing (*Audi alteram partem*). In other words, no person should be condemned unheard. The system seeks to ensure procedural fairness. On the other hand, the inquisitorial system is practised in civil law countries, where rules are codified into comprehensive written statutes rather than shaped by judicial precedent. Under this system, the judge plays an active role in investigating the facts and determining the outcome of the case on the basis of inquiry and investigation. Thus, the precision of decision depends largely on the skills and prudence of the judge concerned.

Changed attitude

The reforms in the criminal law have opened a new avenue for the delivery of justice. To be more appropriate, the Indian Penal Code (IPC) and the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) have been replaced by the *Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita*

(BNS) and *Bhartiya Nagrik Suraksha Sanhita* (BNSS) with the idea of transformation. While the erstwhile penal code was implemented with an idea to punish the accused, the BNS believes in the delivery of justice through retribution. The new code has a democratic approach, placing greater emphasis on individual than on the state in matters relating to crimes. The criminal procedure code believed that trial of a 'criminal' was being conducted whereas the BNSS considers an accused as a citizen whose rights should be balanced with the interests of the victims without any prejudice. Thus, the shift in approach to justice has contributed to making the criminal justice system more democratic and citizen-oriented, while strengthening the protection of the principles of natural justice that are embedded constitutional framework of India.

Reforms in the system

It is well established that every system requires periodic reform to remain responsive to changing needs and circumstances. The judiciary plays a vital role in this process by guiding the state through its directions and rulings. Against this backdrop, it is important to note that courts have laid down procedures governing several aspects of the criminal justice system. Through their decisions, courts often seek to fill legislative gaps in

areas where the law is silent, thereby ensuring the effective administration of justice. For example, the Supreme Court in *Visakha v. State of Rajasthan* (1997) gave guidelines to prevent sexual harassment of women at workplace holding that such an act violates Articles 14, 15 and 21 of the Constitution.

The recent announcement by the Centre to enhance the efficiency of the criminal justice system through digitisation assumes considerable significance. In the field of forensics, the new criminal laws have made forensic examination of crime scenes mandatory for offences punishable with imprisonment of seven years or more. In view of this requirement, the number of forensic laboratories has increased from 129 in 2023 to 154 in 2025. However, according to the National Crime Records Bureau, only 46% of FIRs were digitally transmitted to courts. Since this accounts for less than half of all registered cases, it suggests that the digital chain of the criminal justice system remains incomplete.

Although most states have implemented various components of the criminal justice digitisation system, progress remains uneven. In this context, full digital rollout by 2027 will fill this gap and make the system more efficient.

The author is President, Centre for Applied Research in Governance, Delhi.

